

Part II — Virtual Worlds as Rhetorical Ecologies:

An Ontology, a Method, and Two Designed Worlds

This document assembles the five Part II sections worked through to date — the metaphysics of virtual and phantasmic things, the justification of the method (RODA), the introduction to the applications, and the tutorial analyses of two designed worlds at opposite poles of the medium. The metaphysics keeps its own, more periodic register; the remaining sections hold the figured-but-plain voice of Part I. The §2 disruption analysis of Red Dead Redemption 2 remains pending footage and is noted where it belongs.

1. What Are Virtual and Phantasmic Things?

What is A Virtual Thing?

The conception of the *virtual* and *virtual reality*, as Michael Heim argues, can be traced as far back as Plato and Diotima (Heim, *Virtual Realism*, 18). Philosophically speaking, as Heim observes, “virtual” is a term meaning “not actually, but as if” (Heim, *Virtual Realism*, 220). Etymologically, “virtual” evolved from post-classical Latin’s *virtualis*: “of or relating to power or potency,” that which has the power to produce an effect (“virtual”). Contemporarily speaking, it is used to refer to the virtual environments, objects, persons, and events produced by digital technologies. Considering the wide range of things to which *virtual* can be—and has been—applied, my use of *virtual reality* refers to computer-generated—and mediated—scenes, objects, persons, and events that manifest an interactive virtual environment into which the user is immersed through devices such as Head Mounted Displays (HMD) and handheld controllers.

It is, likely, due to this history and understanding of the virtual and virtual reality technologies that people commonly compare virtual objects to the non-virtual objects they supposedly represent, suggesting that they are not “real” or not as “real” as the things of objective reality.¹ However, I believe this to be a mistaken assumption. Our, often instinctual, responses to virtual objects are an indication of their reality: insofar as a virtual object or thing produces or provokes a response from the user experiencing it is grounds for thinking that a real object is present.

Thus, I occupy a position similar to that taken by Heim and David Chalmers: evinced by their causal powers that are able to affect users, I argue that virtual objects and virtual reality are very much real things, they are just virtual things. However, while I agree with Chalmers and accept that virtual objects are real and not merely fictional or illusory objects, I disagree with the identity claim he makes and which serves as the foundation for his argument: that virtual objects are digital objects. Just as we need to make a distinction between a non-virtual object and a virtual object, so too do we need to make a distinction between a virtual object and the digital object on which it depends.² Accordingly, I will argue against Chalmers and suggest that digital objects and virtual objects are two different *kinds* of objects: a digital object is a *functional* object in that it functions to produce a specific virtual object, whereas a virtual object is a *perceptual* object that is the rendered output of the specific digital object on which it depends. Our work, then, is to pin down the nature of a *digital object*, *digital property*, and *digital event* versus a *virtual object*, *virtual property*, and *virtual event*.³

Before pinning down these distinctions, I want to fix the ontological register in which they operate. To call a thing *virtual* is, etymologically and ontologically, to ascribe to it the character of a *potency*: it is not a finished, freestanding actuality but something *rendered*—brought from potency into act—by an agency that actualizes it. This is precisely Aristotle’s distinction between a first and a second actuality. One who knows English but sits silent possesses that knowledge as a *first actuality*: a developed capacity, fully real, yet unexercised; when one speaks, that knowledge passes into *second actuality*, its active exercise (Aristotle, *De*

¹I want to note that I use the term “objective reality” to refer to the everyday reality outside of or external to that produced by VR technologies. I use “non-virtual” to refer to the objects experienced in everyday, objective reality.

²I use “depend” here and throughout to refer to ontological dependence.

³Here I am taking Jaegwon Kim’s notion of an event as an object and a property that is temporally situated.

Anima, 417a21–b2). A digital object, I will argue, stands to the virtual object it generates as first actuality stands to second: the code persists as a structured and entirely real, but unexercised, potency, while the computer that reads and renders it is the agency that actualizes it into the perceptible virtual object. The non-virtual object, by contrast, is already fully actual; it depends on nothing further in order to be what it is. This actualization of a potency is the genus to which both the virtual object and, as I will later argue, the phantasmic object belong: each is a potency rendered into act by its respective renderer, and each therefore exists only in the act of being so rendered.

I believe we can start to get at the distinction between the two kinds of objects by thinking through the following questions: (1) On what does a virtual object and a digital object ontologically depend? (2) What is the difference between a digital property of a digital object versus a virtual property of a virtual object? (3) What is the difference between a digital event and a virtual event?

On What Does A Virtual Thing Ontologically Depend?

A virtual object, like the lightsaber one is able to wield in the VR program *Trials on Tatooine*, consists of various lines of code which determine its visual properties—such as size, shape, color—as well as what kinds of actions it can and cannot perform or be a part of. This segment of code, and the program overall, is then located in the hard drive of a computer that reads the code and renders the virtual object that is mediated through the HMD. The fact that a specific segment of code or data structure constitutes a certain virtual object leads Chalmers to argue that virtual objects are “digital objects constituted by computational processes on a computer” (Chalmers, “The Virtual and the Real,” 317).

Thus, he understands virtual objects as digital objects that “can be regarded as data structures, which are grounded in computational processes which are themselves grounded in physical processes on one or more computers” (Chalmers, “The Virtual and the Real,” 317). The perceptible properties experienced when we see a virtual lightsaber “directly reflects the properties of this data structure” (Chalmers, “The Virtual and the Real,” 317). Moreover, the interaction of two virtual objects, say the lightsaber and the storm trooper’s blaster fire, is generated “by causal interaction among these data structures” which are themselves “causally active on real computers in the real world” (Chalmers, “The Virtual and the Real,” 317). Therefore, Chalmers’ identity claim derives from and is supported by his argument from causal power: “(1) Virtual objects have certain causal powers (to affect other virtual objects, to affect users, and so on). (2) Digital objects really have those causal powers (and nothing else does). ∴ (3) Virtual objects are digital objects” (Chalmers, “The Virtual and the Real,” 318).

Arguing that virtual objects are digital objects that are *grounded* in computational processes which are *grounded* in physical computers, Chalmers attempts to explain the existence and ontological status of virtual objects in terms of the code, data structures, or digital objects that constitute them which in turn are explained by the computational process of the physical computer. However, while I agree with Chalmers’ characterization of a digital object as a data structure which determines a virtual object’s perceptible properties, there seems to be complications with Chalmers’ identity claim. Firstly, his definition of a digital object could easily be applied to more traditional objects such as the icon for *Microsoft Word* and the program itself would also be qualified as such. Thus, his definition fails to capture the distinction between a virtual object experienced in VR versus other types of digital objects. Secondly, and more important, it seems that a digital object can exist without the virtual object, but a virtual object cannot exist without the digital object on which it depends. This state of affairs is our first clue that virtual objects and digital objects are not identical.

The digital object only depends on the computer which stores and reads it, whereas the virtual object ontologically depends on a particular digital object, the computer that renders it, and the HMD which mediates our experience of it. Even if the computer is turned off the digital object still exists in the computer’s memory, but the rendered virtual object does not. While we might be able to open the program and observe the actual code or digital object as it is stored in the computer, the virtual object which arises from it cannot be perceived without the VR technology that mediates the final rendered output. Virtual objects are real objects insofar as they are images composed of light—a massless object—projected and mediated by the HMD. A specific virtual object, therefore, can only exist when the computer reads the digital object and actively renders it as a virtual object which is projected and mediated through the HMD; the existence of a digital object, on the other hand, needs only the computer in which it is stored. Furthermore, Chalmers’

claim does not seem to adequately capture and explain our experience of virtual objects, and it is in regard to this aspect that his argument does not seem to hold up. When I dodge, say, a storm trooper’s blaster fire headed my way, I am not responding to the data structure or digital object but the perceptual visual and spatial properties of the virtual object the digital object manifests.

Virtual Blueness vs. Digital Blueness

An adept and experienced programmer fluent in the coding language may be able to look at the segment of code and understand that the object will be a lightsaber with such and such properties, but the experience of the virtually rendered object is in no way identical with the experience of observing the digital object on which it depends. Just because a virtual object covaries with⁴ and depends on the digital object does not necessitate that the two objects—and, especially, our experience of them—are identical. Even though the properties of the virtual object are related to the properties of the digital object, the virtual object has properties that the digital object does not: namely, the perceptible properties the user experiences when encountering a virtual thing. You cannot hear the crackling sound of the lightsaber as it moves through the air or see the slight halo of light that radiates from it like heat waves coming off a hot sidewalk by merely examining the digital object on which it depends. You must experience the virtual object in and of itself.

The fact that my virtual lightsaber is virtually blue is dependent on a certain value input in the underlying data structure which generates it, but that data structure or digital object is not blue in any perceptual sense; for the only thing perceived when observing the actual digital object (code) is a series of numbers, letters, and other various signs. At most one might, as Chalmers does, argue that the data structure of the blue lightsaber is *functionally* blue in that it produces or causes a visual experience of the virtual lightsaber as being blue (Chalmers, “The Virtual and the Real,” 321). Thus, we can think about the specific input value or segment of code which *functionally* produces the experience of blueness as a property of the digital object: digital blueness. Because Chalmers’ argument from causal power leads him to identify the virtual object as the digital object which constitutes it, he seems to suggest that the digital object’s property of digital blueness functions as a causal explanation for our experience of the virtual lightsaber’s virtual blueness. But to do so is to conflate two different kinds of properties of two different kinds of objects: the perceptible visual property of the lightsaber’s virtual blueness with the specific value input or digital property (digital blueness) of a digital object that generates or causes that perceptible property.

In regard to our perceptual experience of a virtual object, Chalmers invokes an argument from perception to support his claim.

- (1) When using virtual reality, we perceive (only) virtual objects.
- (2) The objects we perceive are the causal basis of our perceptual experiences.
- (3) When using virtual reality, the causal bases of our perceptual experiences are digital objects.
- ∴
- (4) Virtual objects are digital objects. (Chalmers, “The Virtual and the Real,” 318)

While I agree with his first and second premise, his third premise, though, is problematic. As he continues, a virtual object is a digital object because “many people can see the same digital object by experiencing virtual reality with different displays” (Chalmers, “The Virtual and the Real,” 319), since on his view that digital object is the common causal basis of all of their images.

However, to use his own words, “a moment’s reflection suggests that this cannot be right” (Chalmers, “The Virtual and the Real,” 318-19).

Let us consider if the same digital object (d), the data structure of our virtual lightsaber, is mediated through two different HMDs. One of them is working normally and projects the virtual lightsaber in a particular shade of virtual blue ($b1$), while the other has a slight defect or perhaps is a different brand, causing the virtual blueness of the lightsaber to be projected in a different shade of virtual blue ($b2$). If the blueness of the lightsaber is a functional property of a digital object, this implies that there is a relation between inputs and outputs: the same input will always produce the same output. However, in this example the same input produces two different outputs: $d \rightarrow b_1 \wedge b_2$. So, while we may have the same kind of digital object we have two different instances: $b1$ and $b2$; and, if the objects we perceive are the causal basis of our

⁴For you cannot make a change in the virtual object without making a change in the digital object on which it depends.

perceptual experiences, then, in this case, there are two distinct perceptual experiences, similar though they may be. Because we have, ostensibly, two distinct perceptual experiences of the same digital object suggests that the digital object is not the causal basis of our perceptual experience. The only thing left, therefore, that can occupy such a causal role is the virtual object.

Because, as I mentioned above, our actual experience of the digital object's digital blueness (code or data structure) and the virtual object's virtual blueness (our virtual blue lightsaber) is so drastically different, I believe it is more useful to take a naïve realist stance which suggests that the blueness of the virtual lightsaber is an intrinsic feature or property of the virtual object while the digital object's digital blueness is a functional property. Therefore:

- (1) When using virtual reality, we perceive (only) virtual objects.
- (2) The object we perceive is the causal basis of our perceptual experiences.
- (3) When using virtual reality, the causal bases of our perceptual experiences are virtual objects
- (4) Digital objects are the causal basis of the virtual objects we perceive
- ∴
- (5) Virtual objects are not digital objects.

If this is the case, then it follows that we have two entirely different kinds of properties of two different kinds of objects both of which have their own causal power: the digital object's property of digital blueness functions to cause the veridical blueness of the virtual object that causally explains our experience of the blueness of the virtual lightsaber. Therefore, the relation between the virtual object and our perceptual experience, and the relation between the virtual object and the digital object on which it ontologically depends is *causal* or *explanatory*.

What Is The Difference Between A Digital Event And A Virtual Event?

In his attempt to explain why virtual objects are as real as non-virtual objects and how virtual objects exert causal powers which affect users, Chalmers grounds his explanation in the identity claim that virtual objects are digital objects. In so doing, Chalmers seems to be working to maintain what Kim calls "*the principle of explanatory exclusion*": there can be at most one complete explanation of any given event (Kim, "Explanatory Exclusion," 233). In a sense, when first thinking about a virtual event we are presented with two potential causes for the perceptual event, say, when we first activate the virtual lightsaber and experience its virtual blueness: either the virtual object and its perceptible properties or the digital object on which it depends and generates such.

As Kim notes, there are six possibilities when we seemingly have two causal explanations—the digital object and the virtual object—for the occurrence of one event—my perceptual experience of the lightsaber's virtual blueness.⁵ Chalmers adopts the stance that the two causal explanations are identical; I, on the other hand, see two different events with two different causal explanations. One of the upsides to Kim's explanatory realism is that it helps individuate explanations: "explanations are individuated in terms of the events related by the explanatory relation (the causal relation, for explanations of events)" (Kim, "Explanatory Exclusion," 233). Thus, in the moment I experience the event, the virtual blueness of the virtual lightsaber is explained by—or stands in causal relation to—the veridical, perceptible property of the visual object; and, the virtual blueness of the virtual lightsaber is explained by—or stands in causal relation to—the property of digital blueness of the digital object. In other words, when I turn on the virtual lightsaber and experience its virtual blueness two events are taking place almost simultaneously. (1) A digital event: the computer reads and activates the digital object (code or data structure) and digital property (digital blueness) which causes the corresponding virtual object (virtual lightsaber) and virtual property (virtual blueness) to perceptibly appear mediated through the HMD; and (2) the virtual object's veridical blueness causally explains my perceptual experience of the lightsaber's virtual blueness.

These two events are best understood as the two articulations of a single *occurrence*: the actualization of the digital object's standing potency into the perceptible actuality of the virtual object. Kim's principle is what individuates that occurrence into its distinct events—it is what licenses the claim that there are *two*, and, therefore, that the virtual object is not identical to the digital object on which it depends. The

⁵For more on the six possibilities, see Kim, "Explanatory Exclusion," 233-35.

Aristotelian register names what binds them: the one is the potency, the other its actualization by the rendering computer. The more basic unit, the event as an object exemplifying a property at a time, is in this way nested within the occurrence rather than a replacement for it.

Virtual Objects, Properties, and Events

My distinction between a virtual object and the digital object on which it depends does not invalidate Chalmers' argument that virtual objects are real, but it does, I believe, offer us a more useful philosophical conception of such by allowing us to more fully pin down a virtual object's causal powers which affect the user. Accordingly, I would define a virtual object as the virtually rendered output of a digital object; a virtual property, then, is a perceptible property that is the virtually rendered output of a digital property; and, lastly, a virtual event is the perceptual experience of a virtually rendered digital event. Furthermore, this distinction is useful because it allows us to clarify and individuate between two different explanations for two different events. This individuation, therefore, more wholly captures how virtual objects, virtual properties, and virtual events ontologically depend on and are causally explained by their underlying digital objects, digital properties, and digital events, as well as causally explain our perceptual experience of a virtual event.

What is a Phantasmic Thing

We must now consider other types of virtual artifacts that are revealed in a particular capacity of the human animal: namely, Aristotle's conception of *phantasia*. However, before proceeding, a terminological clarification is in order. The phantasmic object is itself a *virtual* object—not a non-virtual thing of objective reality, but the rendered actualization of a real ground on which it ontologically depends; and, it differs from the virtual-reality object only in *kind*: the virtual-reality object is rendered by a computer and mediated by a head-mounted display, whereas the phantasmic object is rendered by the soul through *phantasia*. If anything, the phantasmic object is the more originary of the two: the imagination renders virtual objects natively, and virtual-reality technology may be understood as a late, external prosthesis for a power the soul has always exercised.

On What Does a Phantasmic Thing Ontologically Depend?

Aristotle states that *phantasia* “does not exist apart from sense perception” (Aristotle, *De Anima*, 428b, 431a). It is initiated when perception occurs, and it continues to function even when direct sensory input is absent. This is why *phantasia* enables one to recall, reconfigure, or anticipate things not currently being perceived. Aristotle further describes *phantasia* as “some kind of movement” produced by sensory activity (Aristotle, *De Anima*, 428b, 431a). This implies that sensory input leaves a residue — a *resonant kinēsis* (κίνησις), the after-motion that lingers in the soul once the object that stirred it has withdrawn — and on which *phantasmata* depend. In this sense, *phantasia* serves as a bridge between perception and cognition. He distinguishes *phantasia* from both thought (*nous*) and perception, emphasizing that it is fallible: “*Phantasia* is an affection [*pathos*] which lies in our power whenever we choose” (Aristotle, *De Anima*, 427b). This suggests that—unlike direct perception, which is always true in its apprehension of its proper objects—*phantasia* can produce false or distorted images based on prior sensory experiences. Logically, then, *phantasia* does not function independently of perception, but instead relies on perception as its ontological ground. In other words, in order to recall an apple we must have *already* experienced an apple either directly or conceptually and have that experience embedded in the soul as a discrete chunk of data. Without this chunk of data, it would not be possible to recall an apple. This residual trace of a perceptible object, which I will refer to as a *resonant thing* or *object*,⁶ is the discrete residual trace of the apple that exists latently, or *potentially* within the soul and serves as the ontological ground for the recollected apple. If that resonant

⁶I use “object” here in the metaphysical sense at issue throughout this section—the relatum of an event, paired with a property and temporally situated—rather than in the sense of a discrete substance. The usage is licensed by Aristotle's own treatment of the residual sense-impressions (*aisthēmata*) as “themselves objects of perception” (*De Insomniis* 2, 460b2–3). This residual trace is what, in Part I, I term the *resonant kinēsis*: the persisting eidetic and orectic impression—the *resonant aisthēma* and *resonant epithymia*—deposited by a completed perception, upon which any later *phantasma* of the perceived object ontologically depends.

object did not exist, it would be impossible for the recollected apple to exist. Or, if a person suffers traumatic brain injury and falls into a persistent vegetative state, despite being alive and still possibly containing the necessary resonant object in their mind, they will be unable to exercise the cognitive processes needed for active recollection. Lastly, the phantasmic apple only exists when the person is actively recalling or imagining it, whereas the resonant object on which it depends exists as a potentiality regardless of whether the person is actualizing it. In other words, the resonant object only depends on the soul of the person where it is stored and which actualizes and renders it as a perceptible object, whereas the phantasmic object ontologically depends on a particular resonant object and the soul of the being that stores, renders, and mediates the perceptible experience. In Aristotle’s idiom, the resonant object is a first actuality—a developed yet unexercised retention of past perception—and the phantasmic object is its second actuality, that retention actively rendered by *phantasia*.

In fact, I believe there are clear similarities between virtual and phantasmic things.⁷ To reiterate, within the context of a digitally rendered object, entity, or event, *virtual* refers to the final rendered output of the digital object. Thus, ontologically, the virtual object depends on the digital object which is grounded in computational processes which are themselves grounded in physical processes on a computer. Analogously, phantasmic things are mental objects (the “perceptible” image) that depend on prior perceptual traces (resonant things) which are grounded in the functions of *phantasia* which are themselves grounded in powers exercised by the ensouled being. There are, however, important disanalogies. The resonant thing is subject to degradation, whereas the digital object—so long as its hardware and code remain unchanged—reproduces the same result identically; the mental trace carries no such guarantee. More telling still is a difference of charge. The perceptual trace carries an orectic weight—it *matters*, as recalled grief is felt as grief—that no data structure possesses; the soul’s rendering is desire-laden in a way the computer’s is not, and it is this charge, latent in the resonant trace and rendered into the phantasma, that the analysis to come will track as the orectic spring of action.

Just as our virtual lightsaber in *Trials of Tatooine* depends on lines of code that determine its perceptible properties, a phantasmic thing depends on a mental trace that derives from direct perception (*aisthēsis*) which I will call a resonant thing. The mental equivalent of a digital object is the stored *resonant kinēsis*, the residual imprint of past sensory experience. These traces are not perceptible as discrete objects in and of themselves, just as a digital object is not perceptibly identical to the virtual object rendered from it. Now, while one might be able to open the file and view the digital code on which a specific virtual object depends, our current technology does not let us actively view residual perceptual traces stored in the soul. Even if one day we are able to see exactly where a specific perceptual trace or resonant thing is stored, it will be perceptibly distinct from the phantasmic thing that we perceive in our mind. Conceptually, however, I believe we can understand the functioning of resonant objects as similar to that of digital objects. Much like how a virtual object only exists when computational processes actively read and project the digital object as a rendered image, a phantasmic thing is only experienced when the mind actively *renders* it through *phantasia*. The mediation of a phantasmic thing occurs through the soul’s faculties rather than an external technological device like an HMD. However, similar to VR, consciousness serves as a mediating apparatus that enables the perception of what is imagined, recalled, or projected. Thus, just as a virtual object requires a functional technological infrastructure to appear, a phantasmic thing requires a functional perceptual and cognitive infrastructure. The virtual object *depends* on the digital object, and the phantasmic thing *depends* on the residual perceptual trace, the resonant thing. It is crucial to note that the perceptual trace can exist without being actively rendered into a phantasmic thing: even when one is not consciously recalling a memory, the perceptual trace that allows for recall remains embedded in the mind. This is akin to a digital object being stored in a computer’s memory even when the virtual object it generates is not being actively rendered. Unlike a digital object, which is stored externally and remains relatively stable, perceptual traces are stored in an embodied, mutable form within the soul’s lived experience. Phantasmic things are, therefore, ontologically dependent entities: they require a ground (perceptual traces or resonant things), an active rendering process and a mediating apparatus (*phantasia*) in order to be and be consciously experienced

⁷The parallel drawn here between the computational case (the digital object and its rendered virtual object) and the mental case (the resonant object and its rendered phantasmic object) is structural and heuristic—a shared logic of a real ground rendered into a perceptible appearance—not an endorsement of any computational theory of mind. The disanalogies are as telling as the analogy: most pointedly, the perceptual trace carries an orectic charge—it *matters* (recalled grief is felt as grief)—that no data structure possesses, so the soul’s rendering is desire-laden in a way the computer’s is not.

(the perceptible object that appears within the mind).

Accordingly, a memory is not a direct imprint of the past but, in the moment it is recalled, a rendered reconstruction (phantasmic thing) of past sensory data (resonant things). It does not exist independently of the soul’s storage and retrieval processes in the same way that a digital object exists even when not being rendered as a virtual object. An imagined object (phantasmic thing) could then be seen as a reconfiguration of resonant things: a combination of past perceptual experiences into a perceptible composition. Like a virtual object rendered from code, it is an active manifestation that requires *phantasia* for mediation. Similarly, projected hopes or fears into the future are future-oriented renders constructed from previous experiences (perceptual traces) and future expectations. They exist within the mind’s capacity for simulation, extending perception beyond the immediate moment into an imagined future.

Lastly, just as virtual objects possess causal powers that serve as an indication of their reality (they interact with other virtual objects, affect people, and produce real-world outcomes), phantasmic things, similarly, are causally operative. For instance, a traumatic memory can affect our emotional responses and decision-making in the future. One can act based on imagined outcomes: a fear of a future wrought by climate change can move someone to act more environmentally responsible in the present. Thus, phantasmic things exert real causal force on the subject, making them ontologically significant beyond mere subjective illusions. Just as is the case with virtual objects where we do not experience the data structure itself (digital object) but the rendered virtual object, so too with our experience of phantasmic things. We do not engage with the resonant things or perceptual traces themselves, but with their reconstructed, rendered forms as phantasmic things. The phantasmic thing may appear directly within the mind’s awareness, but it is mediated by cognitive structures in the same way that a virtual object appears within a VR headset but is mediated by computational structures. Phantasmic things, therefore, are fundamentally and experientially distinct from their perceptual traces or resonant things on which they ontologically depend.

Resonant and Phantasmic Properties

Just as a virtual property (e.g., the virtual blueness of our lightsaber) is causally dependent on the corresponding digital property (the code specifying the object’s color), a phantasmic property (e.g., the recalled warmth of a deceased parent’s embrace or the vivid redness of an imagined apple) is causally dependent on the corresponding resonant property (the stored perceptual trace that enables its reconstruction). This distinction highlights a key ontological relation: the resonant property functions as the causal basis for the phantasmic property; and the phantasmic property is perceptually intrinsic to the phantasmic thing, just as the virtual property is intrinsic to the virtual object. A phantasmic property, then, is not identical to its resonant basis but is instead rendered as an experiential phenomenon in consciousness.

Having laid the ontological grounds, we must now discuss the difference between the functional and perceptual properties of phantasmic things. Resonant properties (functional cause) are the neural or mental structures that store, process, and retrieve perceptual traces and are analogous to the *digital property* of a digital object. These exist even when not being actively experienced. Phantasmic properties are the experienced qualities of a phantasmic thing, such as the imagined color of an object and are analogous to the *virtual property* of a virtual object. They only exist when *phantasia* actively renders them in consciousness. So, a resonant property might be the encoded neural trace of the redness of an apple. Whereas the phantasmic property would be the recalled *vivid red* of that apple when one consciously remembers it. Just as the digital object’s *digital blueness* is not blue in a perceptual sense, a stored resonant trace of an apple’s redness is not *red* in and of itself—the phantasmic redness is only generated when actively recalled.

- (1) When actively contemplating, remembering, or anticipating/projecting, we perceive (only) phantasmic objects⁸
- (2) The object we perceive is the causal basis of our perceptual experiences.
- (3) When actively contemplating, remembering, or anticipating/projecting, the causal bases of our perceptual experiences are phantasmic objects
- (4) Resonant objects are the causal basis of the phantasmic objects we perceive

⁸The inclusion of contemplation is licensed by Aristotle’s thesis that the intellect “never thinks without an image” (Aristotle, *De Anima*, 431a16–17): even when *nous* grasps a universal, a *phantasma* is rendered as its vehicle, so a phantasmic object is present in every exercise of *phantasia* — contemplative no less than recollective or anticipatory — and the premise holds across all three modes.

∴
(5) Phantasmic objects are not resonant objects.

Accordingly, we have two different kinds of properties of two different kinds of things, both of which have their own causal power: the resonant property (the latent perceptual trace) functions to cause the experiential blueness of the phantasmic object, which causally explains our experience of the blueness of the remembered lightsaber. Therefore, the relation between the phantasmic object and our perceptual experience, and the relation between the phantasmic object and the resonant object on which it ontologically depends is *causal* or *explanatory*. To conclude, therefore, I will define “resonant property” (causal input) as “the stored perceptual trace existing latently in the brain” (Perhaps existing “potentially” in the brain and must be actualized”). And, I will define phantasmic properties (perceptible effect) as the perceptible qualities intrinsic to phantasmic things, causally dependent on resonant properties but irreducible to them, and responsible for the phenomenological reality of mental experience. Just as virtual properties determine how we experience a virtual world, phantasmic properties determine how we experience memories, imaginations, and projections—making them ontologically significant and causally powerful.

Resonant and Phantasmic Events

A phantasmic event is the dynamic process by which a phantasmic thing (a memory, an imagined object, or a projected hope/fear) is generated, rendered, and experienced in consciousness. This event unfolds in an ontological hierarchy wherein different layers of reality interact. So, for example, when I am actively recalling turning on the virtual lightsaber for the first time two events are taking place almost simultaneously. (1) A resonant event: *phantasia* reads and actualizes the resonant object (residual perceptual traces) and resonant property (residual resonant blueness) which causes the corresponding phantasmic object (rendered recollection of lightsaber) and phantasmic property (recollected blueness) to perceptibly appear in our consciousness mediated through *phantasia*; and, (2), the phantasmic thing’s phantasmic blueness causally explains my perceptual experience of the recollected lightsaber’s blueness.

A phantasmic event, then, is a temporally situated moment in which a latent resonant thing (residual perceptual trace) and its resonant properties is actualized by *phantasia*, generating a phantasmic thing, which is experienced through its phantasmic properties, resulting in a cognitive-affective response. In other words, a phantasmic event is the perceptible experience of a cognitively rendered resonant event.

- (1) Resonant Thing (Ground): The perceptual trace existing latently in the mind that serves as the causal basis for the phantasmic thing.
- (2) Phantasmic Thing (Rendered Object): The constructed mental representation.
- (3) Resonant Properties (Ground): The specific property of a resonant thing that serves as the causal basis for a phantasmic property.
- (4) Phantasmic Properties (Perceptible Quality of Rendered Object): The rendered experience of the stored trace, the resonant property, actively mediated by *phantasia*.
- (5) Resonant Event (Ground): Actualization of resonant thing and resonant properties (latent perceptual traces) that serves as the causal basis for the phantasmic event.
- (6) Phantasmic Event (Perceptual Experience): The perceptual experience of the rendered resonant event.

Temporally speaking, a phantasmic event unfolds in four distinct phases, corresponding to the actualization, rendering, and experience of the phantasmic thing. Phase 1 - Actualization: begins when the subject’s capacity for *phantasia* is engaged and a perceptual trace (resonant thing and *properties*) is retrieved from the mind and is analogous to a computer reading the digital object before rendering a virtual object. This process may be intentional (e.g., deliberately recalling a past event) or spontaneous (e.g., a memory being triggered by an external sensory stimuli). Phase 2 - Rendering: *phantasia* renders the perceptual trace (resonant thing and *properties*) into a perceptible thing (phantasmic thing and *properties*). This process may involve recombination, distortion, or augmentation (e.g., imagining a new scenario based on past memories), and the phantasmic thing is a rendered mental virtuality. Phase 3 - Phenomenological Presence: the phantasmic thing enters consciousness, where it is perceived with phantasmic properties (e.g., color, shape, emotional tone). The experience is veridical within consciousness even if it does not correspond to present

external reality. Phase 4 - Causal Effects: the phantasmic event influences cognition, emotion, and behavior. For instance, the subject may react emotionally after recalling a nostalgic memory of a deceased loved one, perhaps leading the subject to contacting family members who they may not have spoken to in some time.

A phantasmic event, therefore, is not merely an internal illusion; rather, it possesses real causal power, structuring how an individual engages with the world. Like virtual events, phantasmic events can alter perception, shape emotional states, and influence future actions and/or how we interpret past events. Thus, a phantasmic event operates as mental simulations that actively shape one's understanding of the past and experience of the present and future.

The Three Kinds of Thing and the Data Discrepancy

Let us now consider the differences and similarities between a non-virtual thing, a virtual thing, and a phantasmic thing. A non-virtual apple exists as a physical object in the “objective” world. Its continued existence does not depend on anything once it has come to be; it simply *is*—even when one is not perceiving it. A virtual apple, on the other hand, depends on (i) specific lines of code (the digital object), (ii) the physical hardware that store and render that code (a computational device and computational processes), and (iii) the user's mediating device (e.g. a display or HMD) that renders the virtual apple perceptible. The virtual apple only exists for a subject while the computer program is running and actively rendering the apple in a virtual environment. If the computer is turned off, or the program is closed, the virtual apple ceases to exist as a perceptible object (even if the underlying data structure—the digital object—remains in the computer's memory).

Similar to the virtual apple, the phantasmic apple ontologically depends on (i) a prior experience with a real apple in at least some capacity (directly experienced or perceived through other representations) to create the necessary perceptual trace (resonant object), (ii) the perceptual trace in and of itself, and (iii) the soul of the person that stores and capacity that renders that perceptual trace (a rationally ensouled being and *phantasia* as the capacity or process which reconstructs stored traces into phantasmic things that are perceptually experienced.) The phantasmic apple only exists for the subject who is actively imagining it. If that person were to become suddenly distracted by external stimuli or suffer amnesia and lose the necessary perceptual trace, then the phantasmic apple will cease to exist as a perceptible object (even if the underlying perceptual trace of resonant object still exist within the mind of the subject). Metaphysically speaking, then, the difference between the virtual, phantasmic, and non-virtual apple comes down to the difference between causal and ontological dependence. A non-virtual apple and the tree it comes from have a causal relationship, but once the apple is formed it remains a physically independent entity. The apple does not need the continuing, real-time existence of the tree to remain an apple. In this sense, the non-virtual apple is not ontologically dependent on its tree, but rather is *causally* derived from them. Whereas the virtual apple and its digital object or the phantasmic apple and its resonant object have an ontological relationship: neither the virtual apple nor phantasmic apple *can exist* at any point in time without the active presence (and operation) of the digital code *and* hardware or the resonant object and the soul of the subject which actively render the perceptual events. Therefore, even if the phenomenological human experience of the virtual or phantasmic apple were identical (which they are not) to the experience of the non-virtual apple, the difference in their hierarchy of being dictates that, while they are all very much *real* entities, they are distinct kinds of entities. Whereas the non-virtual and virtual apples are externally experienced, the phantasmic apple exists *internally* within the mind of the *phantasizing* subject that perceives it. Another major difference between, specifically, the virtual and phantasmic apple is that the phantasmic apple requires a perceptual trace or resonant object which in turn requires the person to have actually experienced or learned about apples (through direct perception, testimony, or conceptual learning). In other words, the subject would not have that particular apple-memory or apple-image *unless* they had encountered an apple (or the concept of such) at some point in their life. Once their mind encodes the apple as a resonant object or memory, the existence of that memory no longer requires the *continuing* existence of the actual apple in the real world. You can remember apples that have long since been eaten or decayed. So, the memory or image is *causally* dependent on the real apple having existed in the past (you needed an encounter or some conceptual input), but it is *not* ontologically dependent on the apple still existing now.

To be perceived or recognized as an apple, both the virtual and the phantasmic apple presuppose that appleness has been experienced before—by the designer who models the virtual apple, and by the subject

who recognizes either as an apple. In this sense each gives presence to what is absent: to an apple that was not present before one entered the virtual environment or began to remember. Now let us turn to a consideration of the experience of all the apples. A virtual apple can activate *phantasia* to fill in the gaps—missing smell, taste, weight—by drawing on previous experiences with non-virtual apples. Herein lies a crucial connection between all three types of apples.

As the experiential virtual object ontologically depends on the digital object, and since a digital object like our virtual red apple is made up of a discrete data structure that takes up physical space on our hard drive, we can claim that the amount of data that makes up both the digital and virtual apple are identical. However, even if the amount of data is the same between the digital and virtual apple, our experience of that data is nowhere near the same. The virtual apple primarily consists of mathematical descriptions which create the 3D model: like vertices, polygons, textures, and other attributes needed for rendering a visually similar representation on a computer screen or HMD. Additionally, it can contain information regarding how the apple might move in a simulation, like when I move to pick it up from a virtual fruit bowl. A non-virtual apple includes details like precise atomic composition, surface texture at the microscopic level, smell, tactility, and mass distribution. Accordingly, the virtual apple contains a much smaller data footprint compared to the non-virtual apple’s full complexity. So while both the virtual and non-virtual apple are very much real things, they are two different kinds of things and the primary difference between the two is what I will call, the data discrepancy. Even if every potentiality the non-virtual apple contains could be duplicated in the virtual apple, we still won’t be able to taste it if we take a bite, feel the juice spreading across our tongue, or experience the pleasing scent that wafts up to our nose. However, this data discrepancy only holds true in our current moment. If technology reaches a point where we can inject the human sensorium into a virtual world with the same level of data and potentiality as the non-virtual world, then what is the difference between the non-virtual and virtual apple?

While the data discrepancy is made quite clear when comparing a virtual object to a non-virtual object, we can also see this discrepancy at work in different types of media. For instance, here we have three different depictions of storming Omaha Beach in Normandy France on D-Day. Though profound, the photo fails to capture the same level of intensity that the war documentary does, and that pales in comparison to the clip from *Saving Private Ryan*. Here, we see a gradation in the amount of data presented by each respective media format. Each progressive increase in sensorial data amplifies the viscerally felt response to the content. Thus, simply viewing the photo will not be felt as intensely real as say watching the movie clip. Why? At least one reason and perhaps the defining differentiation is the additional sensorial data. This suggests that media which incorporates a wider gamut of sensorial data will be experienced as more “real.” This is especially true of virtual environments. The more sensorial data it contains as well as how closely it can simulate the total possibilities for action present in a non-virtual environment (lighting, sound, interactivity, realistic entities, etc.), then, potentially, the more “real” it will feel for the person who experiences it. This has profound implications regarding the nature of reality. It suggests that if we can create a virtual apple with the same amount of data and interactive potentialities as a non-virtual apple, and if we are able to wholly immerse the human sensorium into a virtual environment, then our discrete phenomenological experience of the virtual apple will be identical to that of the non-virtual apple. However, this convergence would be merely experiential, and it would leave the deeper difference wholly untouched. Even were our experience of the two apples identical in every sensory respect, they would remain different in kind—for the difference between them was never experiential to begin with, but ontological. The virtual apple is, and remains, a potency rendered into act by a renderer and ontologically dependent upon the digital object that grounds it; the non-virtual apple is already fully actual and depends on nothing further to be what it is. No closing of the data discrepancy can close that gap, for the data discrepancy is a difference of sensory bandwidth, whereas the difference in kind is a difference in mode of being. The two apples may become phenomenologically indistinguishable; they cannot thereby become the same kind of thing. This is also why the limit case—a total verisimilitude that closed the discrepancy entirely—would be no triumph of the real but a foreclosure: a world grown too seamless ever to break is a world that can no longer disclose its own renderedness, and what such a world would conceal is precisely the difference in kind just established.

Each of the three apples is tied to something physical, though not in the same manner. The non-virtual apple is itself a physical thing in objective reality, depending on nothing further for its continued existence; the virtual apple depends on the digital object, which occupies physical space on the hard drive that stores it. The phantasmic apple, however, is not lodged at some site in the brain, as though each memory were an

item filed at an address. Its ground, the resonant trace, is an enmattered modification of the ensouled body itself—a persisting alteration of the living, en-formed body through whose capacity, *phantasia*, the apple is rendered. Its existence therefore depends not on a cerebral coordinate but on the physical integrity of that ensouled body, its matter and its form together; so a grave injury to the brain may leave one simply unable to recall what one once could—not because a stored item has been erased from its place, but because the body that bore the capacity has lost the integrity on which that capacity depended.

The head-mounted display is only the most enclosing case of a more general arrangement. What actualizes a digital object into a perceptible virtual one is a renderer and a display; the headset is one such display, the monitor another, and the structure—a digital object rendered into act and mediated to a perceiver—holds across them. What changes from device to device is not the kind of being produced but the *bandwidth* of its production: how much of the non-virtual object’s full sensorial field the medium supplies, and how much it leaves the perceiver to furnish. This is the data discrepancy named from the side of the world. Named from the side of the perceiver it is its converse, which I will call the *phantasia-load*: the smaller the data a medium delivers, the more the beholder’s own image-making must contribute to make a world of it. A head-mounted, room-tracked world carries a small discrepancy and asks little of *phantasia*; a world rendered on a flat screen and worked through a controller carries a large one and asks a great deal. Both produce virtual objects in the single sense established here, and both enclose a perceiver in a designed world; they differ only in the route by which that enclosure is achieved—and it is that difference of route, not any difference in kind, that the two studies to come will trace.

The data discrepancy, then, is the axis along which these three kinds of thing are ranged: the non-virtual stands at the limit of full sensorial actuality, while the virtual and the phantasmic each present a narrower bandwidth that their respective renderer must actualize from potency. And it is here that the present inquiry reaches its threshold. For the gap between the data a medium presents and the full sensorial field of its non-virtual referent is not left empty: it is *phantasia* that fills it, conscripting the backlog of prior perception to supply what the medium withholds. How that labor is apportioned—how much the medium supplies and how much *phantasia* must contribute—is what sets one medium’s route to the perceiver apart from another’s; but that question, and the larger one of how such rendered worlds come to work upon us and even to reshape us, belongs to the analysis that follows. What the present account has sought to establish is only its proper burden: that virtual and phantasmic things are real, that they are distinct in kind both from the non-virtual and from the grounds on which they depend, and that they share one mode of being—a potency rendered into act.

Where the non-virtual apple is already actualized, the virtual and phantasmic apple exist as a potentiality until actualized by the computational processes or *phantasia* of the person who remembers. Unlike the non-virtual apple, the virtual and phantasmic apple *only* exists for the subject while the VR program is running or actively remembering. If the subject were to lose power or become suddenly distracted while remembering, then the virtual and phantasmic apple cease to exist as a perceptible object (even if the underlying digital or resonant object still exists within the memory of the computer or person).

2. The Justification of the Method

Rhetorical-Ontological Diachronic Analysis: The Mechanism of a Reshaping

The preceding account did one thing only. It held that the virtual and the phantasmic are real — distinct in kind both from the non-virtual and from the grounds on which they hang — and that they share one mode of being: a potency rendered into act. That much is settled. What it set aside — and set aside deliberately — was a question of quite another order: not what the rendered world *is*, but how it comes to work upon, and in time to remake, the one who enters it. The first question was metaphysical. The second is rhetorical — and it calls for a method, not a further ontology. That method is the one I develop here, and I call it Rhetorical-Ontological Diachronic Analysis (RODA).

What RODA does is best said through what it reads. It takes a stretch of play — a bounded run of engagement, motion by motion — and reads it as the *actualization of desire*: the passage of a desiring being from the first stir of perception, through a charged image and a committed judgment, to a completed act. That passage is the object the method traces. It then asks how a designed world drives that passage toward

a substantial union with itself — the union I call *rhetorical incorporation*. And it asks what that union becomes once it is won: it does not lapse when the screen goes dark, but settles into the player's *hexis* (ἕξις, *NE* II.1 1103a16), the standing disposition from which the next encounter sets out. The wager is that engaging and reshaping are not two events but one: the second is the sediment of the first, so that to trace the actualization is already to trace the remaking.

Three words in the method's name mark the three things it must do, and each governs a movement below. The analysis is *diachronic*: it does not photograph a state of involvement but follows a motion through time. It is read forward, then — motion by motion — even as it is understood backward from its end. It is *ontological* before it is psychological: the union it traces is a convergence in being, not a swell of feeling, and for that it must borrow an ontology rather than a vocabulary of affect. And it is *rhetorical*: a world does not merely stand before the player but moves the player, and the grammar of such moving — how an act is given its motive, and how that motive's true source is concealed — belongs to rhetoric as the ancients conceived it. Where the metaphysics carried the reality-burden, the method carries the mechanism.

The Producing Art and the Using Art: What the World Supplies and What the Player Does

The frame beneath the chain is Part I's, not this section's, and I rehearse only the two features the argument leans on. The first is the unity of the change. It is tempting to think that, because a played world has both a maker and a player, there are two changes, each with its own full complement of causes; but the four causes belong to a single change, and they cannot be parcelled out between two agents. Designing and playing are indeed two acts — yet they are joined. They are joined at the relation Aristotle draws between the producing art and the using art (*Phys.* II.2, 194a34–b5): the art that makes the flute is not the art that plays it, and the maker knows the matter while the user knows the form. From this the partition falls out clean. What the world *supplies* — its matter and its form — is the maker's finished product handed over as a given; what the player *does* — the bringing-about and the for-the-sake-of-which — is the using art worked upon that given. The crossing is exact: the designer's end-product is the player's given means. To say that a world *engages* the player, then, names neither a bare meeting nor a metaphor but this precise handing-over, in which the player's own efficient and final causation takes up the world's material and formal supply as the stuff of its act. The designer cannot supply the player's desire, and so cannot be the efficient cause of the player's act; the designer can only shape the world the player meets. Why the act comes *now* is the designer's doing; *which way* it runs is the player's own.

The second feature is the shape of the union toward which the change tends. Part I took this shape from Aristotle's account of perceiver and perceived: "the activity of the sensible object and that of the sense is one and the same activity, and yet the distinction between their being remains" (*DA* III.2, 425b26–27). This is the union-structure the method inherits — one in substrate, different in being — and it must be held with care, for the whole third movement turns on it. It does not say the two collapse into one thing. It says that one actuality is at once the actuality of both, while what it is to be the one differs from what it is to be the other. Agent and world stand so: correlative poles of a single actualization, joined in act, separate in being. This formula, and only this, lets the method speak of a *substantial* union without the absurd consequence that player and world become numerically one.

Rhetorical Incorporation: The Substantial Union of Player and World

The spine of the method is the chain — the actualization-of-desire chain. It is read forward, motion by motion, yet understood backward from the *orekton* (ὀρεκτόν), the desired object that draws the whole toward itself and lends each earlier node its sense, as an end lends sense to a means. It opens at **A**₀, the ontological horizon: a sensible object and the sense-faculty given together within motion and time, the designed *Umwelt* into which the player is always already thrown. The perceptual motion $M_0 \rightarrow A_1$ reaches **A**₁, completed perception, which lays down a dual residue — the *resonant kinēsis*, the after-motion that lingers when the object withdraws, in its two strands: the *resonant aisthēma*, the persisting eidetic trace, and the *resonant epithymia*, the persisting hedonic-orectic tone. The phantastic motion $M_1 \rightarrow A_2$ renders, from that residue, **A**₂, the *phantasma* proper — the determinate, available, charged image on which every later operation works, the pivot of the chain. The cognitive motion $M_2 \rightarrow A_3$ carries the image to **A**₃,

completed cognition: the *phantasma* taken up by the three orientational modes — intellection, memory, the discursive-deliberative — and ratified by the orthogonal committal *doxa* (δόξα), the taking-as-true, in which the emotion concretizes. And the orektikon motion $M_3 \rightarrow A_4$ issues in A_4 , the completed act, which sediments into *hexis*. That cross-pass settling is *temporal sedimentation*, and it must not be confused with the within-pass residue of A_1 ; the two are different deposits at different scales. And the sediment is of two strands. A completed act of skill settles as a *technē*-hexis, the craftsman's standing readiness; a completed act of morally weighted choice settles as an *ethical* hexis, the character's. These are not two chains but two deposits of one — laid down together, each conditioning what the other can become — so that a single stretch of play commonly thickens both at once.

One motion in the chain can also be inverted, and the method must mark the inversion as carefully as it marks the completion. Ordinarily the orektikon motion $M_3 \rightarrow A_4$ issues from the agent's own desire into the agent's own act; but a designed world can *oppose* that desire with a force of its own, and where it does, the agent is made patient — the motion suffered rather than enacted. This is *bia* (βία), forced motion: the standing exception to the chain's agency. It takes several forms the analyses will need — *cinematic* (the cutscene, total patency, the body's control withdrawn entire); *soft* (the rebuff, the invisible wall, the leash that turns the player back without seizing the body); *suffered* (the grapple, the bear's charge, control stripped and won back only by counter-input); *inflicted* (the player as the agent of force upon another); and *de-inverted* (the act that restores to another the agency *bia* had taken). Where the chain runs unbroken to its *orekton*, desire is consummated; where *bia* intervenes, desire is overridden, and the analyst reads an agent momentarily unmade.

The method's central event falls at the $A_3 \rightarrow A_4$ transition, where committed cognition passes into act, and it is in just this passage that the union is consummated. It has two correlative poles, held not as two events but as one: *world-disclosedness* (*Welterschlossenheit*) and *co-disclosedness* (*Miterschlossenheit*). The parallel in the names is the claim itself — one disclosedness, opened at once toward a world and toward others, as one actuality is at once the actuality of both: one in substrate, different in being. In world-disclosedness the player is taken into the world acted in, and the world into the player's awareness — the designed *Umwelt* disclosed as a place dwelt in, not a scene surveyed. In co-disclosedness the same act is an acting-together, a being-with those the player acts alongside — a "we" the act at once presupposes and ratifies. The poles are not successive and not separable: the player drawn into the world is, in the very same motion, drawn into a being-with-others within it.⁹

The convergence is experiential and ontological, an oneness *in act* — and it is emphatically not a change of kind. The player wholly taken into a virtual world has not thereby made that world non-virtual, no more than the perceiver who is one-in-substrate with the perceived has turned the seeing into the thing seen. The reality-burden secured the virtual as a distinct kind of being; rhetorical incorporation does not undo that distinctness but presupposes it.

Incorporation, Re-Grounded: Calleja and the Channels of Involvement

The chain shows that a designed world engages the player's perception, cognition, and desire. What it cannot say, from its own resources, is *where* in the world's design that engaging happens — nor *whether*, in a given case, the player has truly been taken into the world rather than merely set before it. For both the dissertation turns to Gordon Calleja, and it turns to him because his is a vocabulary built from games and tested against players, not deduced from a philosophy of mind. The turning is a sublation, in three beats — a preserving, a transforming, an elevating.

What is *preserved* is incorporation itself, kept as world-disclosedness, together with the six dimensions of Calleja's Player Involvement Model, taken up as so many designed channels through which a world reaches the player along the chain.¹⁰ Calleja's own definition is kept whole: incorporation is "the absorption of a

⁹Both names are Heidegger's. *Welterschlossenheit* is the disclosedness of world — its worldhood; *Miterschlossenheit*, which Macquarrie and Robinson render "co-disclosedness," he states of space, "the essential co-disclosedness of space" (*BT* 145), and I extend it to the co-disclosedness of *others*. *BT* 160 holds the two together: with Dasein's Being-with, the others' "disclosedness has been constituted beforehand," and this "goes to make up significance — that is to say, worldhood." World-disclosedness and co-disclosedness are there co-constituted — disclosed in one stroke, not in succession.

¹⁰The six dimensions of the Player Involvement Model (Calleja, *In-Game*, 43–44; full verbatim articulation in the Calleja appendix): *kinesthetic*, "all modes of avatar or game piece control... ranging from learning controls to the fluency of internalized movement"; *spatial*, "engagement with the spatial qualities of a virtual environment... the sense that they are inhabiting a place,

virtual environment into consciousness, yielding a sense of habitation, which is supported by the systemically upheld embodiment of the player in a single location, as represented by the avatar” (Calleja, *In-Game*, 169); and its double axis with it — the player “incorporates... the game environment into consciousness while simultaneously being incorporated through the avatar into that environment,” where “the simultaneous occurrence of these two processes is a necessary condition for the experience of incorporation” (169). The channels name where the world’s supply presses on the chain; they are named in an analysis only where the world is in fact pressing, never run down as a list to fill.

What is *transformed* is the standing of the concept. In Calleja’s hands incorporation is a psychological intensification of involvement, set on “their experientialist ontology” after Lakoff and Johnson and on “a view of consciousness as an internally generated construct” after Dennett and Damasio (168–169). The reading I develop lifts it from that ground onto another: incorporation is the player’s *dwelling* in the designed *Umwelt* — what Part I, after Heidegger, names “the characteristic absorption of concern in its equipmental world” (BT 405) — the *circumspective concern* in which the tool withdraws into its use, the hammer disappearing into the hammering itself (BT 98). World-disclosedness simply *is* this absorption of concern, redescribed for the virtual world. I must say plainly that this re-grounding is mine and not Calleja’s: Heidegger is absent from his chapter on incorporation, and he reaches instead for cognitive science. Yet his own text invites the move twice over. He grants that “incorporation is ultimately a metaphor like presence or immersion” (3) — and a metaphor leaves its ontological debt unpaid; and there is a gap, plain on the page, between the experientialist ground he claims and the phenomenological words he in fact reaches for, the “sense of habitation,” the “inhabiting a place.” The re-grounding does not import a foreign vocabulary so much as pay for the one he had already spent.

What is *elevated* is incorporation’s reach: no longer the whole of the union but one of its two poles, joined to co-disclosedness within a single event. And the joining is prefigured in Calleja’s own list — for one of the six dimensions, the shared, already names involvement with one’s fellows, and so points past the world toward co-disclosedness. Here Calleja earns his place as an instrument and not an ornament, for his own writing yields a test of incorporation against mere involvement, which the method numbers and extends as the criteria R1–R7 and makes the gauge of world-disclosedness.¹¹ The strictest gatekeeper is R3, simultaneity, which is Calleja’s own necessary condition; the cornerstone is R4, the spatial-and-kinesthetic base “without [which] incorporation cannot take place” (170). The union-claim is thereby kept from mere assertion: it is read off conditions, and it returns a verdict — incorporation achieved, partial, merely-involved, or ruptured.

Why Calleja, and not another account of immersion or presence? The answer runs through his own correcting moves, not through a contest with rivals. He excises the magic circle, that supposed clean wall between the played world and the lived one — and the excision is exactly what a world real in kind demands, since what is real in kind cannot be sealed behind such a membrane. And he corrects the one-way metaphors of immersion and presence, which figure the player as merely lowered into a world; his double axis restores the two-way traffic — the world taken into awareness as much as the player given over into the world — that “one in substrate, different in being” requires.

Consubstantiation and the Grammar of Motives: Burke at the Other Pole

Incorporation joins the player to the world acted in. It does not join the player to those acted alongside; and the chain, which tells what moved the player, does not tell how that motion is afterward rendered, nor how its true source comes to be concealed. Two things are left unaccounted for, then — and neither is a *residue* in the sense the term carries here, but each is a real gap: first, a consubstantial bond among several agents, a “we” that can itself *source* an act, so that the deed springs from the bond and not from any single locus;

rather than merely perceiving a representation of space”; *shared*, “engagement derived from players’ awareness of and interaction with other agents... cohabitation, cooperation, and competition”; *narrative*, “the narrative that is scripted into the game and the narrative that is generated from the ongoing interaction with the game world, its embedded objects and inhabitants, and the events that occur there”; *affective*, “various forms of emotional engagement... either purposefully designed into the game or precipitated by an individual player’s interpretation of in-game events and interactions with other players”; *ludic*, “players’ engagement with the choices made in the game and the repercussions of those choices.”

¹¹The incorporation criteria (Calleja, *In-Game*, 169–173, 178; full articulation in the Calleja appendix): R1 assimilation; R2 embodiment; R3 simultaneity (the strictest gatekeeper, Calleja’s own necessary condition); R4 the spatial-kinesthetic cornerstone; R5 blending; R6 temporal apex; R7 intrusion-integration. R3–R7 are Calleja’s own incorporation-versus-involvement test; R1–R2 are drawn from the double axis.

second, a grammar by which a finished act is furnished with its motive, and by which that motive's source may be displaced. For both the dissertation turns to Kenneth Burke, and the turning is again a sublation.

What is *preserved* is consubstantiation. "In being identified with B," Burke writes, "A is 'substantially one' with a person other than himself. Yet at the same time he remains unique, an individual locus of motives. Thus he is both joined and separate" (Burke, *Rhetoric*, 21). That "joined and separate" is, word for word, the grammar of "one in substrate, different in being," and its ground is act: "substance... was an act; and a way of life is an acting-together" (21). The bond, moreover, is born of division and answers to it — "Identification is affirmed with earnestness precisely because there is division. Identification is compensatory to division" (22) — and the player arrives divided in the most literal way, an actual body set over against the avatar acted as. What is *transformed* is the engine of the bond. For Burke the "we" is worked by symbolic persuasion; in the method it is worked by shared desire — the "we" ratified at A₃, where the committed cognition of agents acting together fixes a common *orekton*. What is *elevated* is its place: consubstantiation becomes co-disclosedness, correlative to world-disclosedness, and folded into what Part I called the affective architecture of bodily-being-in-the-world-with-others.

The grammar of motives Burke supplies on his own warrant. He "refers human actions to seven causes (*aitia*): chance, nature, compulsion, habit, reason, anger, and desire" (Burke, *Grammar*, 292) — and that warrants reading the seven causes of *Rhetorica* I.10 (1369a5–6) as a table of motive. The crosswalk from those seven to the pentad is mine, built on Burke's own move. His explicit map runs from the *four* causes; I mark the difference rather than blur it. The pentad itself — Act, Scene, Agent, Agency, Purpose, with Attitude as the sixth term¹² — the method takes as a grammar of motive-*attribution*, "a concern with the terms alone" (xvi), not a psychology of the drives beneath an act: it names what a finished deed gets ascribed to, and lets one and the same deed be relocated from term to term. To it attaches a concealment diagnostic, which I frame narrowly and not as a blanket suspicion: "in banishing the term, far from banishing its functions one merely conceals them," so that the analyst may "detect its covert influence even in cases where it is overtly absent" (21). The diagnostic catches a displaced motive — a source smuggled in under another term's name, as when an act the agent in fact sourced is re-credited to the Scene that merely housed it — and claims nothing more sweeping than that.

One last piece of evidence binds the two sources into one. Calleja, grounding incorporation in cognitive science, and Burke, grounding consubstantiation in symbolic action, arrive — each blind to the other, neither citing the other — at the very same figure of the joined-yet-separate: Calleja's two-way axis and Burke's "both joined and separate." Two inquiries that set out from incompatible grounds and come to rest on one structure are not thereby proven right, but they are strongly corroborated; where the same form is deposited by hands that never met, it is likeliest that the form lies in the matter and not in the eye. That one structure is what the method names rhetorical incorporation — and world-disclosedness and co-disclosedness are not two lenses laid over a scene, but the two poles a single convergence brings to light.

3. Introduction to the Applications

The Virtual Environment as Rhetorical Ecology

Over the course of his career, Jakob von Uexküll would conceive and propose a radical new perspective for zoological studies: a new way to perceive the relationship between the organism and its environment. Dissatisfied with the traditional scientific perspective which saw a single world within which all living organisms are hierarchically situated, he argued that every living creature exists within a species-specific, perhaps even within an individual-specific, perceptual world: "for everything a subject perceives belongs to its perception world [Merkwelt], and everything it produces, to its effect world [Wirkwelt]" (42). The receptor and effect systems constitute the organism's "functional circle" (49)—contemporarily rephrased as a "feedback loop"—and "these two worlds, of perception and production of effects, form one closed unit, the environment" (42).

¹²The dramatic pentad (Burke, *Grammar*, xv; full articulation in the Burke appendix): Act ("what was done"), Scene ("when or where it was done"), Agent ("who did it"), Agency ("how he did it"), and Purpose ("why"). Attitude — "the preparation for an act," an "incipient act" (Burke, *Grammar*, 20) — Burke subordinates to Agent in the 1945 text and promotes to a sixth term only in the 1969 edition; I take it here as that sixth term.

Accordingly, there are an infinite variety of perceptual worlds as each individual's subjective environment [Umwelt] —metaphorically figured as a "soap bubble" which encloses the subject on all sides—is determined by their respective capacities for perception and production of effects. This perspective not only helps to blur the hierarchical distinction and prioritization between humans and animals, in that all organisms are now understood to perceive and react to environmental sense-data as signs, but also lays the groundwork for Heidegger's deep ontological adaptation of Umwelt to articulate human being-in-the-world. Indeed, as Heidegger argues, "[t]hat world of everyday Dasein which is closest to it, is the environment" (BT 94). Thus, it seems as if for both scholars the environment or Umwelt constitutes the grounds through which the perceiving subject comes to be, it "forms a self-enclosed unit, which is governed in all its parts by its meaning for the subject" (Uexküll 144).

While Uexküll primarily focused on examining the animal environment, Heidegger's method of analyzing human being by situating it within an environmental context reinvigorates the concept of environment within a human perspective: it is no longer something "out there," as the natural world against the world of human creation, but rather serves as the overarching orientation through which things are related to other things. Heidegger's reoriented understanding of environment works to break down the dichotomy between natural and artificial or built environments by figuring environment as the network or "totality of involvements" within which all understanding and possibilities for action originate. Indeed, as Katherine Hayles comments, this is a conception of environment as the "crucial scaffolding and support for human cognition" (92). In Gibsonian terms, the environment contains the total sum of possible affordances for thought and action for the respective subject: "[i]t implies the complementarity of the animal and the environment" (119).

According to Timothy Morton, "[i]n order to have an environment, you have to have a space for it; in order to have an idea of an environment, you need ideas of space (and place)" (11). The spatial character of the environment, which Heidegger articulates through his analysis of the structure of "worldhood" as a context of relationships, suggests that "the entities in a world are constituted by their interrelationships ... a continual linking of one thing with another" (Heim Virtual 91). Lefebvre seizes on the interconnected nature of spatial environments and poses a new way to understand the lived environment of the human subject. He was one of the first to highlight the fact that our environment not only shapes who we are and how we understand our place in the world, but also how "real" lived space is constructed through social practices: social relations "project themselves into a space, becoming inscribed there, and in the process producing that space itself" (129). The key element to Lefebvre's thinking, according to Hayles, "is conceptualizing place not as a fixed site with stable boundaries but rather as a dynamic set of interrelations in constant interaction with the wider world, which nevertheless take their flavor and energy from the locality they help to define" (185).

Lefebvre's work helps us understand how a built environment is inflected with various ideologies and political implications and demonstrates how those environments work, in turn, to inflect our lived experience of them. Sarah Ahmed illustrates this in her critique of institutional spaces as "orientation devices" which are shaped by "what resides within them" (157). In other words, these spaces are shaped by the bodies that built and occupy them and thereby orient our encounter with other bodies' experience within them. To return to the natural environment/built environment binary, we can see that fundamentally they function in the same way: they orient our understanding, actions, and experiences in the world. Just as the institutional space orients those who occupy it, so too does the natural world. If, on a hike, we hear the telltale sound of a rattlesnake, our orientation is directed to a potential threat and that plays a dramatic role in our future actions. Therefore, in essence, all environments, artificial or natural, exert fundamental rhetorical force that directs our attention and moves us to do something. However, while all environments are fundamentally rhetorical, there are undoubtedly different kinds of environments. The university or academic environment is a very different environment than, say, Yosemite in regard to the objects and entities that populate each respectively. As such, I believe we need to make a distinction between environment and ecology. Accordingly, I define "environment," as a specific, bounded location wherein circulation between various interrelations take place; and although circulation can occur throughout multiple environments, the rhetorical effects, analytically speaking, are best examined within a particular localized system. That said, I believe it is better to consider the rhetorical force exerted by environments along ecological lines. For me, "ecology" represents the broader, all-encompassing scale of multiple environments. As such, I use "ecology" to describe the theoretical lens through which we can understand the rhetorical effects of environments in general; in other words, "rhetorical ecologies."

Even if how a specific individual makes sense of their position within a specific environment and how they conceive the possibilities for action, for the production of effects, is linguistically circumscribed, both space and language itself is affected by and embedded with various environmental, cultural, institutional, and political perspectives. Our practical consciousness, therefore, is not an isolated product. It does not, as Jenny Edbauer argues, exist "outside the prior and ongoing structures of feeling that shape the social field," the interconnection of forces, rhetorics, moods, and environmental, social, and political histories that cohere around material spaces and physical locations (10); rather, our practical consciousness is formed in relation to the dynamic rhetorical ecology into which we are born and live our lives. To this end, Thomas Rickert recasts rhetoric's work as ambient and ontological: "persuasion gains its bearings from an affectability that emerges with our material environments both prior to and alongside the human" (254). This way of being forces us to recognize that our engagement with environments and the things within them not as just simple objects, but rather as active constituents of the world that shape us and are shaped by us. Indeed, as Heidegger concludes, rhetoric is the self-interpretation "of concrete being-there, the hermeneutic of being-there itself" (Concepts 75); rhetoric is the means by which we understand our being-in-the-world and how our environmental context shapes this understanding. An understanding of the rhetorical force exerted by environments as ambiance dissolves the dichotomy between "passive" material environments and human action in favor of, what Byron Hawk calls, "emergent entanglements that tacitly coproduce dwelling" (20).

Human understanding and discourse does not simply take place within a specific environment, it takes shape within dynamic relations between human nature, environment, and social infrastructures. Indeed, a change in, for example, our material information environment brings with it a change in human being. Social media in particular is a great example to understand how a change in our environment can lead to fundamental changes in our everyday being-in-the-world. It exemplifies how new media environments fostered through new technologies of communication transform how we understand these new techno-social matrices. In short, it demonstrates how an environment isn't merely shaped by us, but how it plays a role in who we are, how we know, as well as what we say and do. Our everyday environment serves as the backdrop through which things and objects show up as what they are, as we conceive and understand them. However, as Rickert emphasizes, our everyday environment is already "choreographed in advance" (55) and thereby rhetorically shapes our primordial understanding of it. Therefore, the range of our thoughts, expressions, and discourses is shaped by our dynamic rhetorical ecology: the concatenation of and interaction with other objects, entities, peoples, discourses, material environments, social norms, and economic and governmental institutions and policies. And it is within such rhetorical ecologies that individual and collective self-determination is realized. What an understanding of rhetorical ecologies discloses or opens to us is a complex, dynamic, and relational world consisting of mutually interacting elements which do not outright control or predetermine our experiences, but rather rhetorically attune us to the affective and symbolic ground from which consciousness, lived experience, and willed activity is derived.

If every environment is a rhetorical ecology — orienting its inhabitants, attuning them, and over time re-making the being of those who dwell within it — then the virtual environment is that proposition carried to its limit. A natural or built environment is choreographed only in part: shaped by histories, materials, and forces no single hand has authored, much of it withdraws from any design. The virtual environment is choreographed entire. Nothing in it is found; everything is rendered. Each perception-mark and effect-mark, each affordance and functional tone, each law of the place is laid down in advance by a designer, so that the choreography Rickert discerns in all dwelling becomes, in the virtual, a nearly total authorship of the world.

Such a world has no objective referent. It does not depict a reality lying behind it; it simulates one outright — a simulacrum in a deliberately minimal, Baudrillardian sense, a situation rendered rather than the representation of a prior one, though without Baudrillard's stronger claim that no real lies behind it at all, since the foregoing ontology has located that real ground precisely in the digital object — "the generation by models of a real without origin or reality" (Baudrillard, *Simulacra and Simulation*, 1). The virtual environment is therefore situational in the strongest sense: not a scene the user surveys from without but a world the user is within, a designed Umwelt whose every relation has been set so as to orient and move the one it encloses. This is what may be called a persuasive virtual ecology — the affordance-structured horizon within which the user comes to perceive and to act; named in the present terms, it is simply a rhetorical ecology every element of which is authored.

The designer is thus the hidden agent of the whole ecology, the efficient cause for which the rendered world stands in. And yet — this is the crux — a wholly authored environment does not on that account

determine the one who enters it. It attunes. The player who moves through such a world acts from a desire that is genuinely the player's own, even where the ecology has been arranged so that the player's desire and the designer's end fall into alignment. In just this sense the virtual environment is the purest instrument of environmental rhetoric: it curates without coercing, moving its inhabitant to act not by instruction but by the very disposition of a world. What in the natural environment is diffuse and unauthored — the rattlesnake's rattle bending a hiker's next step — is here total and deliberate, and so can be studied in isolation.

But to say that a virtual environment attunes those it encloses already presumes that they are, in some genuine sense, enclosed — taken up into the world rather than set before it as a picture. What that being-taken-up amounts to, and why the older language of "presence" must give way to a language of incorporation, is the next question.

From Presence to Incorporation

To be enclosed by a rhetorical ecology and moved by it is, in the language of virtual-reality research, to be *present*. The dominant accounts define presence as the sense of inhabiting a mediated world "as if ... only mediated by human senses and perceptual processes" (ISPR par. 2) — a co-location felt below cognition, registering as the involuntary flinch or the stumble at an edge that is not there. Presence in this sense is, as Perelman and Olbrechts-Tyteca said of rhetorical presence generally, something that "acts directly on our sensibility" and is operative "at the level of perception" (116). It is, moreover, a matter of degree: worlds are more or less convincingly inhabited, and presence is to be distinguished from mere *immersion* — the engrossment in an activity better described, with Heidegger, as a "concernful absorption" (BT 146) in a task than as a feeling of being-there.

In my earlier work I pressed this distinction toward a limit I called *true presence*: the condition reached when the apparatus falls transparent and the division between a subject and a world of objects dissolves, so that the user is no longer set over against the virtual world but absorbed into it — present as a craftsman is present in the work, not as a spectator before a picture. That criterion — equipment-transparency and the dissolved subject/object — I keep. The name I do not.

For "presence," even qualified, carries a psychologistic and faintly binary cast: a state of mind one is in or out of, registered on a felt scale. It sits poorly with what the analyses to come will show — an achievement built up motion by motion, across distinct channels, over time. I therefore set the term aside and take up, from Gordon Calleja, the more exact one: *incorporation* (Calleja, *In-Game*) — the very union the foregoing method anatomized into its two correlative poles, world- and co-disclosedness. Incorporation names a double movement: the player assimilates the virtual environment into the field of habit and attention and, in the very same stroke, comes to be incorporated *into* it — present within the world as one who dwells there. It is graded, embodied, and processual, gathered across several dimensions of involvement at once; and it preserves what "true presence" rightly saw — the transparent equipment, the dissolved subject and object — now as its achieved condition rather than its definition. To be incorporated into a designed environment is to have come to dwell in it. The difference from mere presence is not academic. A spectator before a vivid but non-interactive panorama is *present* to it as to a picture, set over against a world that does not answer; the player who lifts a fallen fruit and carries it to a waiting goblin, or who pours a morning coffee in a gang's camp and is greeted by name, is *incorporated* — taken up into the world as one who dwells and acts there, the world taken up into the player in the same stroke. It is that achieved, two-way dwelling, and not a felt intensity registered on a scale, that the analyses to come will track.

Veri(dis)similitude: The Aim, Function, and Motive of the Virtual

If incorporation is what a designed environment accomplishes, the next question is *how* — by what aim, function, and motive a rendered world draws the player in. The triad is Heideggerian: a phenomenon is delimited by asking what it is for, what it does, and what moves it (BT 24, 29).

The motive is legible in the name. "Virtual," in Burke's sense, is an *epithet* — a word that assigns a substance and thereby carries an implicit program of action (*GoM* 57); and etymologically it means "not

actually, but as if” (Heim 220), from the Latin *virtualis*, power or potency (OED). The motive of the virtual, then, is to be taken *as* the real — to pass, for the duration of the experience, as indistinguishable from the actual. From this motive follows a double function. *Technically*, virtual-reality technology functions to **supplant** objective reality: to evacuate the real-world horizon and render another in its place. *Rhetorically*, it functions as an **actant** (Latour 373; Gries 74–75) — the rendered world is not an inert backdrop but a granted source of action that works upon the user by symbolic and material means (Burke, *RoM* 43). The rhetorical ecology of the foregoing pages, seen now from the side of the maker, is just this: an environment authored to act.

To supplant reality and be taken as real, however, a rendered world must satisfy a double and paradoxical condition, which I name **veri(dis)similitude**. It must be *verisimilar* enough — “familiar enough to our normal everyday mode of interacting and understanding objective reality” — for the player to be thrown into it at all; and it must be *dissimilar* enough — holding possibilities “dissimilar to what is familiarly experienced in everyday objective reality” — that what it then does to the player can carry ontological force (*Veri(dis)similitude* 9). The credibility a virtual world must win merely to be entered — its *ethos* as a world — is the verisimilar pole of this condition; its power to re-make those who enter is the dissimilar pole. A world too familiar cannot move; a world too strange cannot be entered. Only the veri(dis)similar world both throws the player in and, having done so, can rupture and re-ground. The verisimilar pole has a technical name already given in the ontology — the *data-discrepancy*, the gap between what a medium renders and the full sensorial field of what it renders — and an experiential one, the *phantasia-load*, the labor of image-making by which the player fills that gap. Veri(dis)similitude, data-discrepancy, and phantasia-load are thus one condition seen in turn from three sides: from rhetoric, from the medium, and from the player who must make a world of what the medium supplies.

Two Worlds at the Poles of the Medium

Two designed worlds anchor what follows, chosen because they stand at opposite poles of the medium. *Gnomes & Goblins* (Wevr and Reality One, 2016) is a virtual-reality world at the near edge of the virtual: room-scale, headset-supplanted, its data-discrepancy small and its demand on the player’s image-making correspondingly light. *Red Dead Redemption 2* (Rockstar, 2018) is a screen-based world at the far edge: rendered on a flat display and worked through a controller, its data-discrepancy large and its demand on the player’s image-making correspondingly heavy. Each is a rhetorical ecology built to incorporate; set side by side, they let us watch how the medium’s data-discrepancy sets the *route* to incorporation — and to the ontological change it can carry — without either pole holding a monopoly on the end. That comparison is drawn out on its own terms in the differential analysis that closes these readings; here it is enough that the two cases are not rival demonstrations of one thing but a controlled variation, the medium changed and the rest held as steady as two such worlds allow.

Each world is read in the same two movements. First the **tutorial** — how the design, without instruction, naturalizes its mechanics and draws the player from a being-in-the-world toward a being-in-a-virtual-world. Then the **disruption** — the engineered rupture at which the incorporated world breaks and, in breaking, discloses what it had quietly made of the one who dwelt in it. The first case is *Gnomes & Goblins*.

4. *Gnomes & Goblins*

The Tutorial: Coming to Dwell

The Candle: A Threshold Crossed by Discovery

Before the forest there is a threshold, and it must be worked. The world opens onto a night scene and a signpost, each of its directions hung with an unlit candle, a single lit candle resting on a stump nearby. One instruction is given, and only one: a player who thinks to look at the tracked hands finds a line of text — take up the lit candle, set its flame to an unlit one. Even that much resists. Lighting the candle is “more difficult than one might imagine; it takes some experimenting” with the flame before it catches and a way opens (Salvo, *Veri(dis)similitude*, 31 — the author’s earlier study of this same world).

What the fumbling teaches is not only a grip but a meaning. The signpost first reads as a signpost — a trail-marker, a "direction tone," pointing the ways one might go; the candles, things that simply burn. Only in the handling do they turn into something else: an apparatus, an "interface tone," a control the player must operate to begin the experience at all (Salvo, *Veri(dis)similitude*, 31). And nothing announces the turn. The lone instruction names the task but not the meaning; the shift from sign to interface is authored by the player, out of the player's own trying. Here, in miniature, is the method the whole world will run on — a functional sense withheld and then conscripted from the player's own image-making (*phantasia*) rather than declared.

Nothing in this is yet dwelling. The player stands at the edge of the world and not within it — assimilation barely begun, the first skill (*technē*, τέχνη) of grip and reach taking hold, no surround yet closed around the player and no thing yet mattering. What the candle installs is precisely the disposition the rest will build upon and the rupture will eventually turn: a habit of finding the world's sense by working at it, cued by almost nothing. The flame catches; the unlit candle on the road marked *Goblins* takes light; and the menu gives way to a forest.

The Forest: Dwelling, and What Withholds

The forest receives the player bodily. What the menu's flat dark gave way to is a place with depth and weather — treehouses, rope bridges, a canopy that stirs in wind — and the player is not before it but within it, standing where a moment ago there was a room. This is the designed surround the reading will keep returning to: an *Umwelt*, in Uexküll's sense — a surrounding world closed about the one who lives in it like a membrane, furnished to be inhabited rather than surveyed (Salvo, *Veri(dis)similitude*, 27). And in virtual reality the inhabiting is literal. Room-scale tracking renders a real step as a step among the trees and a real reach as a reach toward them, one to one; the hands that move in the forest are the player's own, tracked, with no avatar interposed. The spatial and bodily floor of any dwelling — the felt sense of being somewhere, able to move and to handle — is here not conscripted from imagination but supplied by the medium. The cornerstone of the dwelling is set in the body.

For a time the world simply obliges. Shutters open to a hand laid on them; sticks and bridges sway when pushed; a fallen fruit can be lifted, an acorn taken up. The forest answers the player's dealings smoothly and at once, and a fluency builds — each handled thing confirming the last, the circuit of perceiving-and-doing that Uexküll called the functional circle closing again and again until the movements ask no thought. This is how the dwelling is laid down: not declared but accreted, motion by motion, a skill thickening into the settled ease of being at home somewhere.

One thing, though, refuses. A curiously shaped rock lies on the ground, and the hand that reaches to take it closes on nothing it can use: the rock is, in the earlier report's words, "resistant or entirely unserviceable" (Salvo, *Veri(dis)similitude*, 40). It cannot be lifted, moved, or turned to any task; and in refusing, it shows what the obliging world had kept hidden. The compliant objects had been ready-to-hand, equipment so transparent in use that it drew no notice; the rock, balking, goes un-ready-to-hand in Heidegger's sense — the thing that announces itself precisely by breaking down under the hand reaching for it. What balks is then set aside. The rock falls out of the player's dealings and becomes a mere perception-image, a thing that, in proving unusable, ceases to matter.

What refuses in this way is, in Rickert's sense, a thing rather than an object — something whose being is not exhausted by what can be done with it, exceeding the use-relation and withdrawing into a depth no dealing reaches (see Heidegger, *Being and Time*, 102–107; Rickert, *Ambient Rhetoric*, 199–201). Almost everything else in the forest conceals that withdrawal by complying; the rock, in refusing, makes it briefly palpable. And yet such open refusal is not this world's main way with the player. The forest dwells the player less by pushing back than by holding back — withholding cues, withholding instruction, withholding the meaning of its candles and the consequence, soon, of its bell, and leaving the player to supply what is kept from view. The rock withdraws from use; the design withholds the world's sense; and both throw the player onto the same conscripted image-making. What looks like a generous, obliging world is in this one respect austere: it hands over its objects readily and its meanings almost never.

Into this dwelling a first relation is seeded. A goblin appears — shy, glimpsed at the edges, then nearer. So the dwelling stands: a body at home in a tracked space, a fluency that needs no thought, a world of things that mostly answer and one that would not, a creature met. What the design then makes of that

dwelling — how it turns a fluent body and a met creature into a deed the player was never told to do — the next moment shows most plainly.

The Fruit: How a World Moves the Player Without a Word

Of all the moments in the opening, the fruit exchange is the one in which the design's method is most nakedly itself. It moves the player to do exactly what it wants — pick up a fruit and give it to a goblin — without a single instruction, and it does so by arranging a world rather than issuing a command. Walked through the actualization of desire step by step, the curation becomes legible; and because nothing here is carried by narration or told outright, the scene is the cleanest demonstration the artifact offers of environmental rhetoric at work.

The chain begins before the fruit falls, at the horizon (A_0). By this point the player has had some minutes of unguided play — opening shutters, lifting acorns and sticks, pushing branches — and from that play a disposition has quietly settled: in this world, things are to be picked up. The forest has also, moments earlier, produced a goblin, so that the horizon now holds not only a field of graspable objects but a creature the player has begun to attend to. Neither disposition was taught; both were cultivated by the design, and both are about to be drawn upon.

The trigger is a sound. High in a tree a goblin sets to the fruit, and the player hears the chopping before seeing it — a sound the headset anchors in space, turning the head toward its source. This is the first and subtlest stroke of curation: attention itself is directed, at the level of perception (A_1), by an authored cue, so that the player looks up in time to watch the goblin work the fruit loose and see it fall to the moss (06:52.8). What the perception deposits is not yet a plan but a charge — a thing has just come free, and it has come to rest at the player's own level.

From that charged perception the player forms the image of a possible act (A_2): *a fruit I can pick up*. The image is under-determined — nothing has said what the fruit is for — but it is not conjured from nothing. It is filled out from the disposition the free play laid down, the settled sense that the graspable thing is to be grasped. The design has withheld all instruction; and into that withholding the player's own image-making (*phantasia*, φαντασία) supplies the act the design declines to name.

What turns *pick it up* into *give it to the goblin* is a second authored cue. As the player takes up the fruit, the goblin draws near and waits — and goes on waiting — its posture legible as expectancy (A_3). On that cue the player ratifies a settled judgment (*doxa*, δόξα): this just fell, and the creature wants it. No line of text proposes the gift; the goblin's bare expectant nearness, read through the player's own *phantasia*, does. The mood that colours the judgment is the helping tone the encounter has already set — curiosity tipping over into care.

And so the player acts (A_4): carries the fruit to the goblin and sets it on the ground between them (07:13.3). The act is the player's own — a voluntary motion sourced in a curiosity become helpfulness, a desiderative (*epithymetic*) impulse completing itself as a wish (a bouletic *orexis*) to help, its means, the offering, deliberately chosen. Nothing forces it; it is no forced motion (*bia*, βία). The freedom is real. But the freedom lies in the engaging, not in the outcome: the design has so arranged the scene — the chop, the fall to eye level, the patient wait — that of everything the player might do, this is the act made salient, made likely, very nearly made inevitable. Here is the whole principle of the thing — curation, not coercion: the player does just what the designer intends, and does it freely.

The goblin's part seals the reading. It does not take the fruit at once; it waits some eight seconds, then bends, lifts it, and carries it off (07:21.7). That delay is the tell. The goblin is not a fellow agent answering a gift but a scripted trigger firing on a timer — programmed responsiveness, the efficient causation of the hidden agent, the programmer, for which the goblin's "wanting" stands in. The player reads none of this: *phantasia* fills the pause as expectancy and the script as intention, so that a timed retrieval is lived as a creature's gratitude.

What the exchange leaves behind ($A_4 \rightarrow A_0'$) is small and real: a helping tie where there was none, and with it the first sediment of an ethical disposition (*hexis*, ἕξις) toward the goblin — the player is now one who has helped, and the world one in which help is taken up and answered. The Shared dimension of involvement, dormant until now, has opened; the dwelling has gained a second person. It is this seeded relation that the later beats presuppose and deepen — the descent among the goblins, and, before it, the rupture the whole dwelling makes possible.

Read whole, the fruit exchange is the persuasive virtual ecology in miniature. Every cause but two is the designer's: the fruit, the goblin, the sound, the fall, the wait, and the rule that binds them. The two that remain the player's — the desire that moves the act and the end it serves — are exactly the ones the design cannot author and has no need to, because it has built a world in which the player's desire and the designer's end fall into a single line. To curate an environment, on this evidence, is to arrange the conditions under which a free act becomes the likely one: to move someone to do what you would have them do by handing them a world, and never a word.

The Disruption: Rupture and Carry-Over

The Miniaturization: A Rupture That Re-Incorporates

By the time the gold bell lies on the moss at the tree-base, the player has already come to dwell. The opening minutes do their quiet work: a fluent grip on the controls, a path learned by walking it, a goblin met and handed a fallen fruit — a skill (*technē*) settled into a disposition (*hexis*, ἕξις) and a relationship begun, sedimented motion by motion, until the forest is no longer a scene surveyed but a place inhabited. It is into this dwelling that the bell is rung; and what the ringing does turns on its having been rung from within a world already the player's own.

The act itself is small, and entirely the player's. Curiosity moves it — what does this bell do? — a desire (*epithymia*, ἐπιθυμία) sourced in the player and in no goal the design has set; and the means is chosen, the bell raised and sounded as a deliberate probe. The ringing is thus no *bouletic* act sourced in some end the world has set, but a *prohairesis* one: a bare *epithymetic* impulse — curiosity — completing itself by a deliberately chosen means, which is what *prohairesis* is, the deliberative completion of a wish and not a fourth kind of motive beside the three desires. What the player cannot author is the consequence. The design withholds it: nothing on the bell, nothing in the wordless world, declares what ringing will bring. So the charged image the player acts from — the *phantasma* (φάντασμα) of a bell to be rung — is under-determined as to its outcome, filled out from the player's own settled judgment (*doxa*, δόξα) that bells make a pleasant noise. The freedom is real but placed: it lies in the *whether*, the choosing to ring, not in the *what-it-does*, which is foreclosed.

Then the world overwrites the image. Fireflies wake and swirl, light saturates to white, and the point of view drops as the world swells — grass risen into trees, the human scale of a moment before collapsed to the scale of an insect (07:48–08:14). For this the player has no fore-structure; the *phantasma* rung from is exceeded, not fulfilled. And yet the rupture does not expel. The player is transformed, not dragged from the agent's place to the patient's — movement, gaze, a second ringing all remain — and the change runs with the player's desire rather than against it, and so it is no forced motion (*bia*, βία), no cutscene seizing the body, but a designed and productive rupture. What it ruptures is the scale at which the player was incorporated; what it leaves intact is the incorporation itself.

It is the deepest of several breakdowns the world can spring, and the only one that re-incorporates. A thing had already withdrawn from use — the rock that would not be handled — and disclosed, in withdrawing, that the world need not yield; the apparatus itself can fail, the headset slipping or the power cutting, and disclose the rendered world as rendered by tearing it away — in that failure one event befalls the digital object the machine still holds and another befalls the virtual world the player inhabited, which simply ceases; even a held image can flip, gestalt-like, and unsettle perception for a beat. Each is a rupture that discloses by breaking. The miniaturization breaks more deeply than any of them — it remakes the very scale of being-in-the-world — and yet, alone among them, it breaks without expelling: the disclosure it works is undergone from within a dwelling it does not end.

This is why the shock lands as wonder and not as dread. The mood the forest had set — a childish, unguarded delight — colours the perceptual moment before the transformation arrives, so that when the world gives way the emotion concretized is anxiety in its disclosive register and not its threatening one: the vertigo of a ground withdrawn, recovered almost at once into the poise of an agent still standing. Anxiety (*Angst*) here individualizes without unhoming for good.

Rendered as motive, the episode runs on a single ratio. The player attributes the change to the bell, to the world — *the scene did it* — and the scene, in transforming, transforms what the agent is and can do: a Scene–Act relation, the container reshaping the contained (Burke, *Grammar*, 443). Two terms go concealed

in that attribution, as a banished term goes on doing its work unseen (Burke, *Grammar*, 21): the player's own settled readiness to ring intriguing things, and the maker who wrote the rule — the programmer, the hidden Agent for whose efficient causation the magic stands in.

Read as union, the beat is the height of the whole arc. Everything the forest had built — the fluent body, the inhabited space, the wonder, the dawning story — is co-active at once, and incorporation reaches the apex of its climb from off-line anticipation to absorbed play (Calleja, *In-Game*, 178). The rupture is then the limit case of the strictest condition: an intrusion that does not break the absorption but is taken up into it (Calleja, *In-Game*, 172), the porosity by which the world's most violent move deepens rather than dispels belonging — the dissimilar shock re-incorporating the player at a new scale instead of casting the player out. World-disclosedness (*Welterschlossenheit*) — for Heidegger, disclosed equiprimordially with the others who share the world and with one's own existence (Heidegger, *Being and Time*, 176) — is not undone but re-pitched: the designed surround is disclosed again, smaller and stranger, and again as a place to be dwelt in.

This is *veri(dis)similitude* made event. A world verisimilar enough to be entered through fluent dwelling is broken open by a possibility dissimilar enough that the breaking carries ontological force; and the force is disclosive. What the miniaturization lays bare — what it *unconceals* — is the contingency of a constitution that ordinarily withdraws from notice: that the player's scale, orientation, and standing in a world are not given but rendered, and can be rendered otherwise. The bell that worked the rupture becomes, now, a way through: rung again, it teleports, and the player moves by it among the small world's places — the threshold at which world-disclosedness turns toward the others who dwell there.

The Tavern: Co-Disclosedness at Its Threshold

Rung from within the miniaturized world, the bell no longer transforms; it carries. Each ringing sets the player down in a new place among the tiny world's locations, and one of these is a tavern — a drinking-hall built for a crowd, its long tables and benches and scattered mugs sized for company, lamplit and warm. Two goblins are at home in it: one asleep, one bent over a drink (08:56–09:16). Nothing here is staged for the player's coming. The room and its dwellers go on with a life of their own; and what the place discloses, in disclosing that life, is the goblins' being-with-one-another — a way of living together already under way before the player arrived among it, and not pausing for the arrival.

To be set down in that hall is to undergo one of the founding disclosures of being-in-a-world. The world the player now inhabits is a with-world: its dwellers come forward not as objects met but as others already living together, so that to enter their place is to receive the "disclosedness of the Dasein-with of Others" that belongs to every being-with (Heidegger, *Being and Time*, 160). And the disclosure runs both ways. At some of the bell's destinations a goblin lifts its head and looks — a small thing, and the whole of it: in the returned look the other is given as an other, and the player as one who is there to be seen, co-present in a shared place. Co-disclosedness (*Miterschlossenheit*) opens here not as a doctrine but as this mutual look across a lamplit room.

Read as motive, the tavern works by what Burke names consubstantiation — a shared substance built out of shared act. "A way of life is an acting-together," and in acting together the members come to hold the sensations and attitudes that make them of one stuff (Burke, *Rhetoric*, 21). The goblins' communal drinking is just such an acting-together, their consubstantial way of life made visible; and the warmth of the inhabited scene works on the player as the sympathetic imagination works, rendering the goblin-world present as something that matters, something to belong to, before any deed is done among them (Burke, *Rhetoric*, 83–84). What the player cannot do is enter the substance. Admitted to the hall and co-present in it, the player remains "both joined and separate" (Burke, *Rhetoric*, 21) in the thinnest register the phrase will bear: joined as a guest is joined, present and unturned-away; separate as a stranger is separate, unaddressed, no member of the we that drinks.

For the joining stops at the look. The goblins drink and sleep and raise their heads, but they never act with the player — never hand a cup, never make room at the table, never take up a common task. Their motion is programmed responsiveness, scripted by the hidden maker whose efficient causation the world's life stands in for; and what fills it out as a life — the sense that someone is genuinely at home behind the drinking — is supplied by the player's own image-making (*phantasia*, φαντασία). The goblins hold no settled disposition (*hexis*, ἕξις) of their own to extend, so nothing in them can close upon the player as a fellow.

The acting-together is given to be witnessed and not to be entered. What the design discloses, then, is the co-world entire — the shared dwelling, the others at home in it, the look that grants co-presence — and what it withholds is the single thing that would consummate the bond: a deed done together. The consubstantial "we" is not merely nascent here, waiting on more time; it is structurally held back, designed out — whether by deliberate authorial choice or by the limits of the NPC system, the analytic result is one and the same — shown as a thing the player may stand inside of and yet have no part in. This is co-disclosedness given as a preview — the disclosure of being-with isolated, deliberately, from its enactment.

So the small world holds the player at two depths at once. World-disclosedness is sustained and even widened: the bell that re-scaled the surround now ferries the player through it at will, and the dwelling deepens with each place entered. Co-disclosedness arrives, but only to its threshold — the co-world and the mutual look disclosed, the acting-together kept just beyond reach. These are not two unions but one incorporation disclosing along its two poles — one in substrate, different in being; and *Gnomes & Goblins*, by opening the second pole exactly to the edge of consummation and no further, lets that single incorporation be seen as a consummated collective never could. That the co-world shows at all, even with its enactment withheld, is the work of the same disclosive power the rupture exercised in the breaking — the power of the rendered world to make briefly visible what it silently constitutes.

Carry-Over: The Unconcealing and What It Leaves Behind

The rupture's deepest work is not the change of scale but the change of sight. A world dwelt in withdraws from notice; the fluent body, the inhabited place, the standing from which one acts do their work precisely by going unremarked — the hammer disappearing into the hammering. What the miniaturization does is break that transparency for an instant, and in breaking it, show it. The player who has come to dwell at human scale is handed, without warning, a world in which grass stands like trees; and the gift is not the new scale but the sudden visibility of the old one *as* a scale — one rendering among possible others, contingent where it had seemed simply given. This is an unconcealing: the breakdown lays bare the ordinarily-hidden constitution of being-in-a-world, the way a tool laid bare in its failing discloses the whole equipmental web that had silently carried it.

The mood is the proof. Anxiety (*Angst*) is not here a failure of absorption but its disclosive limit — the affect in which the player's enworldment, having lost its footing, comes into view *as* enworldment. Anxiety individualizes: it draws the one who undergoes it out of the absorbed, anonymous everyday and sets the bare fact of being-in-a-world before the player. The miniaturization works that individualizing stroke in little, and works it as wonder rather than dread; but the structure holds. What had been lived is, for a moment, seen.

This recasts the union itself. To be incorporated into a designed world is, by default, to be absorbed in it uncritically — a dwelling at once genuine and fallen. The fallenness is precise: the world's significance comes pre-articulated, settled in advance as the anonymous "they" settles the sense of the everyday, so that the player takes on trust a meaning another has authored; the player is drawn ever onward by curiosity, which for Heidegger is less a thirst for the new than a fleeing of oneself into whatever distracts; and beneath both, the player is constituted as a functional object of the programmer's design, moved through a possibility-space foreclosed in advance — every choice, like the chord already lying in the piano before the child's hand finds it, available only because it was built in (Adorno, *Aesthetic Theory*, 32). Incorporation left to itself is this fallen union. The rupture is what can convert it: by making the constitution visible, the unconcealing opens the possibility of a dwelling no longer merely undergone but owned — a critical, individualized inhabiting in place of an absorbed one. The productive rupture is thus not the enemy of incorporation but its completion: the point at which a union that was only suffered becomes one that can be answered for.

And the disclosure does not end when the headset comes off. A single first-hand datum marks the carry-over: after several hours in the rendered world, the return to the unrendered one is not immediate — for a quarter-hour or so the actual world wears the strangeness the virtual one had shed, the eye reaching for a scale no longer there, the body carrying an orientation the room will not answer. The report behind that description is first-hand and exact: the return brought "the odd sensation that I remained tethered to the computer," depth-perception briefly unreliable, and the disturbance held until "it took around 15 minutes for my phenomenological and ontological orientation to recalibrate to my 'Being-in-the-world' of objective reality" (Salvo, *Veri(dis)similitude*, 58 n. 15). The disposition sedimented across hours of dwelling carries

over the threshold of the exit and presses, for a time, upon the disposition it had left behind. This is the actualization chain closing its longest loop: the completed act settling into a standing disposition (*hexis*, ἕξις), and the disposition outlasting the world that laid it down.

The verdict the evidence will bear is partial but real — a transient supplanting of the player’s dispositional ground, an alteration of settled orientation deep enough to bend how the actual world is met on return. It must be held within a limit. The virtual is distinct in kind from the non-virtual; no depth of carry-over converts the rendered world into an unrendered one, and no recalibration makes the player a new kind of being. What the carry-over alters is the *how* of a dwelling, not the *what* of a substance — an alteration (*alloiōsis*, ἀλλοίωσις) so deep it strains toward a remaking of character and yet, the virtual keeping its kind, cannot become one. The supplanting inflects the disposition; it does not author a new soul.

Here the method earns its stake. If a designed world can drive the actualization of desire to a substantial union, and if that union sediments into a disposition that carries past the world’s edge, then to design such worlds is to design dispositions — a rhetoric that works not on belief but on the standing from which belief and action set out. The miniaturization is a small and benign instance: a moment of wonder that, by unconcealing the contingency of a place, leaves the one who undergoes it faintly re-pitched toward the world. The instance is small; the principle is not. It is the warrant for taking the rendered world seriously as a maker of who its inhabitants are becoming — and the charge under which the design of such worlds must be thought.

5. *Red Dead Redemption 2* (§1: The Tutorial)

Where *Gnomes & Goblins* withholds instruction and lets the player discover, *Red Dead Redemption 2* withholds freedom and scripts the discovery — and the inversion is the whole difference between the two poles of the medium. The virtual-reality world trusts the player to find meaning in an open surround, the candle and the goblin and the fallen fruit each yielding only to a hand that works at them and none of it explained. The screen-based world takes the opposite wager, placing the player in a prepared corridor and running a full curriculum through it, mechanics and ethics alike, before the world opens at all. The rails are the tutorial — not its scaffolding and not its constraint, but its argument.

That argument is built upon a *hexis* (ἕξις), or rather upon two of them, woven from the first interactive clip so tightly that to pull one loose is to unravel the other. The first is a *technē*-hexis of the craftsman-outlaw — horsemanship, gunplay, the tracker’s eye, and the heist-man’s deliberate hand — installed across three hours of structured play and then left to run untutored. The second is an ethical hexis of the desiring, dwelling, gang-loyal, morally-scored agent — laid down in Dutch’s grief-speech before the controller arrives, deepened by camp labor and morning greetings, calibrated by the honor machine across five consecutive resolutions in a single clip, and finally spoken aloud by the man himself in a half-lit confession to one he has just spared and just threatened. Neither hexis precedes the other; they are not two programs run in sequence but one bundle cultivated at once, each conditioning what the other can become.

Three times across that cultivation the governing desire — the *orekton* (ὀρεκτόν) that orients the whole — is re-pitched to higher ground. Blizzard-survival names it first: warmth, food, and shelter for the gang, the bare needful goods against a storm that is as much curriculum as weather. Standing-and-belonging names it second: being of use inside Dutch’s world, earning one’s place, mattering to the people of Horseshoe Overlook. The outlaw economy names it third: the fence-unlock that turns a one-off robbery into a standing livelihood, the gang’s prosperity made the shared object of desire. Each pitch carries the same hexis-bundle forward and adds to it a layer the next will draw upon, so that the player who begins as a patient in a cutscene — an unnamed body in a blizzard, led by the reins — is the very player who, hours later, acts in silence with a bow drawn on legendary prey and needs no narrator to name what is happening. It begins, before any mechanic, with a name.

(Clip numbers below are the raw capture indices of the playthrough, not a continuous sequence; the analysis leans on the named beats and cites a clip only where a timestamp anchors a quotation.)

The Opening Cutscene: Identity Before Embodiment

The chapter opens not on a player but on a spectator: for nearly six minutes the controller does nothing, the game is a film, and the player watches. This is the tutorial's first lesson, and it names itself as no lesson at all — for before the first mechanic is installed, before a horse is ridden or a rifle raised, the cutscene builds the ethical horizon within which every mechanic will afterward be used, planting a *hexis* of gang-loyalty as the orienting good before the player has had any occasion to act upon it. What the section establishes is the 2D pole's founding reversal: on the flat screen, identity is given before embodiment, the name before the deed.

The opening frames set the condition of patience. The Van der Linde gang flees through the Grizzlies in a blizzard — on horseback, on foot, carrying its wounded — and the player watches without acting, made patient by the medium's own conditions. This is *bia* (βία) in its softest and most total form, not the sudden seizure of an ambush but the structural withholding the cinematic form itself enacts. And it arrives where the data is thinnest, for what the blizzard-screen delivers — white static, wind, indistinct shapes laboring through snow — is very nearly nothing. Near-zero data is where the high-*phantasia*-load pole announces itself most loudly: everything the player registers of this world, the felt cold and the gang's desperation and the depth of the ravine they cross, is supplied not by the screen but by the player's own image-making (*phantasia*, φαντασία) from the backlog of prior perception. The screen primes; the player fills.

Into that primed reservoir Dutch van der Linde speaks. Between 04:11 and 05:01, in a speech the gang does not interrupt, he names the dead — "Davy... Jenny..." — grieves them, and rallies the living: "Stay with me. We ain't done yet" (clip 1, 05:18). What the speech installs, before the player has moved a thumb, is the ethical *hexis* of gang-loyalty: the disposition to hold the gang's survival as the governing good, to count its losses as losses that matter, and to follow Dutch because Dutch is the one still standing and still steering. "There was nothing more you could have done" (clip 1, 03:42) — the exculpatory frame opens here and will run the length of the campaign, attributing every loss to circumstance rather than to any agent's failure, to the storm and the Blackwater catastrophe and a world arrayed against the gang. This is the Burkean scene-act ratio running for the first time, the scene-term absorbing the moral weight that might otherwise land on the agent; the player is handed the lens before ever being handed its object.

Dutch's charged face, the gathered gang behind him, the grief and the rally together compose the *phantasma* that will orient every loyalty-*doxa* the player forms across the game's duration — and they compose it by the high-*phantasia*-load method in its purest form. On a 2D screen a speech is exactly where the data-discrepancy is total, flat image and audio with no body to enact anything, and exactly where *phantasia*-load runs to its maximum: Dutch's authority, the gang's need, the whole moral economy of survival are supplied from the player's own image-making in response to a voice and a face on glass. The master phantasma of Dutch-as-father-of-the-cause is built entirely so, and built before the player has done anything at all.

One detail seals the reading. At 05:47 Dutch says "We've got some work to do" and the controller becomes active — but Arthur has already been named, already addressed as "the only one I can rely on to stay strong right now" (clip 1, 01:13). On the 2D pole identity precedes embodiment: the player is told who he is before he is given anything to do, and where a head-mounted world would place a body in space and leave it to orient itself from the ground of sensory presence, the flat screen gives the name first and the body second. Arthur exists before the player inhabits him; the ethical horizon exists before the mechanic does. The off-screen Blackwater catastrophe drives the point home — "What really went down back there on that boat?" / "We missed you. That's what happened" (clip 1, 06:00) — for the originating event, the job that killed Davy and Jenny, is never shown, and *phantasia* must constitute it entire from dialogue and tone and the grief inhabiting Dutch's face. Maximal data-discrepancy is here a narrative method: the game withholds the origin and conscripts the player to supply it, so that he begins already inside a crisis, already mourning people he never met, already indebted to a man whose speech he has merely watched. The controller arrives second.

The Leash: What the Blizzard Hides

The clip that follows the cutscene runs twenty-nine seconds, and it is the tutorial's most important negative space — important not for what it does but for what it withholds, and for what the withholding installs.

What the section establishes is that on the 2D pole the very thinness of the image, the medium's standing handicap, can be turned into an instrument of concealment.

The player rides out of Colter in a column with the gang, into a screen that is near-total white. "This goddamn weather," a companion says; "Been two days or more like this now" (clip 2, 00:00). The data-discrepancy is here at its maximum for a flat screen, the visual field reduced to a blizzard that is nearly nothing, so that depth and terrain and the cold weight of the air and the gang's silhouettes resolving from the white must all be supplied by *phantasia* from the player's own reservoir of hard mornings. Where a head-mounted display would deliver stereoscopic depth, the vestibular confirmation of a body in space, and the heft of cold through haptics, the 2D screen gives white static and wind. The world is maximally *phantasia*-borne, the 2D pole's standing condition carried to its extreme.

At 00:11 the player strays from the scripted trail, and the world declines to yield. "I think you're going the wrong way" — the sentence falls, companion and NPC and the voice of the designed path at once, and the player is turned back. No wall is visible, for the blizzard has hidden it; no instruction is offered, for the world simply will not give way to the off-track vector. The designed scene exerts what Burke called the recalcitrance of the situation, an ambient resistance that, as Rickert reads it, belongs to the material environment and not only to the persuading speaker (Rickert, *Ambient Rhetoric*, 254). It is also a soft *bia*, a micro-inversion of agency by which the agent is made briefly patient to the scene's insistence on its own path. No force is applied and no cutscene strips control; the companion's line stands in for the invisible wall, and the player re-corrects.

What the blizzard does for the leash is precisely what the leash cannot do for itself: it conceals the corral. Where virtual reality would betray a hard boundary by stereoscopic depth — the wall seen as a wall, the horizon held at a distance the body cannot ignore — the 2D blizzard withholds the geometry entire. The high-*phantasia*-load that is the pole's standing challenge becomes its instrument of concealment, since a boundary that cannot be seen can be read as the world's weather rather than the design's constraint. The medium's very limitation, its inability to render the depth that would reveal the wall, is what enables the tutorial's first sleight of hand.

What settles across these twenty-nine seconds is not a skill. No A_4 completes, nothing is finished, the *orekton* is posited but not satisfied. What settles is something more basic and more lasting — the *hexis* of being-led, the disposition of path-adherence, the trained readiness to stay with the column and go where the column goes. It is a privative deposit, not a positive capacity but a negative one, defining the horizon's edges by enforcing them and so making the later open world legible as release: the player must feel the leash to feel the moment it is loosed, and the blizzard, in hiding the wall, makes that lesson more effective than any visible boundary could.

The Colter Corridor: A Curriculum Under Fire

After the leash comes the corridor, and the corridor makes the chapter's widest claim — that *Red Dead Redemption 2*'s tutorial installs not one *hexis* but two, not in sequence but together, in the same clip and the same thirty-eight minutes of on-rails play. The Colter sequence threads a full control curriculum — mounted movement, free-look, combat, inventory, melee grapple, horse-handling, tracking, Eagle Eye, weapon-selection — through a narrative that requires each mechanic to justify itself as a story-need, so that no menu announces itself and every skill is introduced by the world demanding it. But the curriculum carries a shadow curriculum, and the shadow is ethical: alongside each skill the player learns, the world deposits a disposition. (The clip's interleaved fork, capture 3a, is the choke/spare beat that occurs within this same in-game session but was beatmapped separately. It returns at the section's close as the curriculum's diagnostic zero.)

The corridor opens with movement, and with movement's constraint. "Stay close. We'll do our best to stick to the trail," a companion says; "Careful over this bridge here" (clip 3, 00:28–00:30). Companion patter scripts every footfall, and navigational agency belongs to the gang and not the player. The leash of clip 2 returns now in narrative form, the only way being Dutch's way, and the *hexis* of being-led deepens through story where before it deepened through rebuff. At 04:17 the camera opens — Dutch places Arthur in the cattle shed and the player finds the first mechanic of the gaze, the free-look, the 2D surrogate for the turned head — and where a head-mounted player turns to look with the whole body, here the look is a

stick-driven symbolic act, the whole phantasia-load of "being there" resting on a camera's movement through a flat frame.

The first combat arrives at 07:08 with a recognition and an eruption — "It's goddamn Dutch Van der Linde!" / "Shit! Look out! There's more of the bastards!" — and the O'Driscoll ambush routes embodiment through *phantasia* rather than through a headset. The involuntary reflex at the on-screen muzzle-flash, the body pulling back from a threat on a flat surface, is the 2D pole's defining register of embodiment, the felt body of danger substituting for the spatial surround the headset would supply. It fires here for the first time. The armed O'Driscoll becomes the *phantasma* charged with threat; the committal *doxa* (δόξα) — *this is an enemy, to be met with force* — forms and concretizes; the shot closes the chain. So the *technē*-hexis of combat seeds itself not by instruction but by an attack the player must survive — which is already the section's lesson in miniature, that the skill and the disposition are installed in one motion.

Inventory arrives under looting's cover. "Turn the place upside down. Grab as many supplies as you can" (clip 3, 09:00), and the satchel-UI becomes the tutorial's first pure data-discrepancy beat, the act of rifling a dead man's home — the texture of wood, the smell of blood, the weight of a tin — thinned to a menu of icons and a text prompt. And inside the looting a single line catches and will not be cleared away: "Poor bastard was married too" (clip 3, 13:52). It is no mechanic but a moral residue the Burkean scene-term must absorb and paper over; the scene absorbs it, and the line remains.

At 14:52 the barn grapple reverses the combat's structure, and the player is seized: an O'Driscoll lunges from behind, control is momentarily stripped, and the player is made patient by the world rather than active in it — *bia* suffered, the agent-to-patient inversion in its acute form, recovered only by counter-input. Then, within thirty seconds, its mirror, as the prisoner is beaten for information (clip 3, 15:30): *bia* inflicted, the player now the agent of force. Both poles of the *bia*-arc fall inside a single half-minute, neither scored by the honor machine and neither a deliberated act, the kinesthetic grammar of violence installed at the tutorial's speed.

What follows is where the dual-hexis claim becomes most precise. Dutch hands Arthur lethal discretion — "Do what you want with him. I don't care. But bring that horse when you're done" (clip 3, 16:00) — the prisoner begs, and Arthur releases him: "Get the hell outta here! Go!" This is the first *prohairesis* (προαίρεσις) the player makes in the game, a freely chosen mercy over a fully realized patient of *bia*, a man on his knees asking to live. And the honor machine scores the act and attributes it to the agent — not to the scene, not to Dutch's permission, but to Arthur's character. The *technē*-hexis and the ethical hexis are thus installed in the same clip, the same half-hour, the same breathing sequence of mechanics: the player who learns to shoot at 07:08 is the player who learns to spare at 16:00, and the curriculum is dual from its outset.

Sadie Adler's rescue follows at 18:00, where Micah manhandles a hidden woman — "Get away from me!" — and Arthur and Dutch intervene: "Leave her alone. She ain't one of them" (clip 3, 18:00). Micah's *bia* against Sadie is met by Arthur's agency-restoring force, and the gang's self-understanding arrives in a single line — "We're bad men. We ain't them" — so that the ethical hexis of in-group distinction, defined not against a positive ideal but against the O'Driscolls, is planted in the space between that line and the deed it names. Horse-handling, tracking, Eagle Eye, and the weapon-wheel arrive between 17:00 and 29:00 under the same narrative cover, each mechanic a story-need. And Eagle Eye, toggled at 24:00, is the tutorial's first explicit perception-prosthesis, a vision-mode supplying in highlighted tracks and scat what a trained tracker's gaze would otherwise hold as bodily knowledge without a UI. The 2D screen cannot deliver the trained eye, so it grants a filter that stands in for the eye. At the canyon traversal (29:00–31:00) the companion patten tightens the leash once more — "It's slippery. Be careful. / Stay close to the wall. / Get up here" — and soft *bia* returns as the sustained scripting of every footfall. Then, at 33:00, the wolves: $A_2 \rightarrow A_3 \rightarrow A_4$ on repeat under time-pressure, the lunging animal as *phantasma*, the snap *doxa* (*threat, kill it*), the shot — and the flinch firing again, sharper now, because the wolves lunge and the screen can place the body nowhere but here. "Good work, Arthur" (clip 3, 38:10): the act attributed to the agent's competence, the *technē*-hexis of combat-under-duress named and affirmed.

Against this whole sequence the choke/spare fork stands as the tutorial's diagnostic zero. In the interleaved beat (capture 3a) Dutch hands Arthur the same lethal discretion, and this time the honor machine scores nothing: a choke and a spare are mechanically identical, and the only phenomenal residue of a life-or-death act is the tolling of a bell (clip 3a, 11:31–11:45). Set beside the prisoner release, where mercy was scored and credited to the agent, this fork is machine-inert — the most intimate and most morally charged

choice in the tutorial falling silent — and what the bell does is exactly what the meter declines to do: it carries the moral weight aesthetically, affectively, without attribution. So the honor machine’s selectivity is established from the outset. The witnessed, publicly legible mercy scores; the intimate maximal choice, made in private with a pleading man and no witnesses, leaves only a bell-toll and a silence.

The Hunt: A Desire Made Legible

Against the corridor’s density and pace the hunting tutorial is something rarer — a chain that Charles narrates aloud, stage by stage, so that the actualization of desire can be watched as it happens. The clip is useful not because the chain requires narration to run, for it runs whether or not anyone speaks it, but because Charles verbalizes each stage and so makes the apparatus’s operation, everywhere else smuggled under story, unusually legible. That legibility is the section’s reason for being.

The chain begins before any animal appears, at the horizon. “A few cans of food and a rabbit... for 10, 12 people?” (clip 4, 00:58) — the scarcity is designed, and the design is plain: the camp cannot be fed on what it has, and so someone must go. The *orekton* — food, survival, the gang provisioned against the storm — is installed before the hunt begins, so that the kill will read, from the moment it is made possible, as provision and not as the agent’s bloodlust. The motive is pre-assigned, the act licensed in advance, coded as a scene-and-purpose deed the honor machine will not need to stir for. Charles hands the bow at 02:24 — “You take this. I can’t use it and you’ll have to” — and the weapon specifies the *technē*: a silent kill, the bow chosen because the gun would scatter the prey. They climb the mountain, Charles reads the terrain aloud, and the scarcity-horizon follows them up into the trees.

At 06:10 the trained perception the analysis calls A_1 , the uptake of the world’s offered residues, is modeled by the tutor before the player performs it: “There’s deer been here. Recently. How can you tell? / How can you not?” The Eagle Eye vision-mode is toggled, the screen’s track-highlights supplying what a trained hunter’s gaze would otherwise hold as body-knowledge without a UI — the 2D pole’s perception-prosthesis at its most explicit, since the tracker does not develop a tracker’s eye over years in a single session but presses a button and the game paints the ground. “It’s easier in the snow, but once you get your eye in, you’ll be able to track them nearly as well in grass and woods” (clip 4, 06:28): the *hexis* is named as portable, a disposition that will carry from terrain to terrain, the game framing aloud the very thing it is cultivating.

“Good tension on the string before releasing. Just don’t overdo it. Now, Arthur” (clip 4, 07:52). The bow draws, the tension-indicator runs, the reticle steadies, the arrow flies. In four seconds the full chain closes — A_2 (the deer as *phantasma* charged with the *orekton* of the kill), A_3 (the *doxa*: *this is the shot, take it*), A_4 (the kill). The felt body of the drawn bow — the tension across the back, the steadied shoulder, the held breath — is entirely *phantasia*-supplied behind a button-hold and an analog stick. The mechanic abstracts the act, *phantasia* supplies its body, and four seconds of screen-time close what three minutes of narrated preparation had opened. “Let’s try for another” (clip 4, 08:04): the loop is set to repeat, because repetition is how a *hexis* sediments.

“Easier when they ain’t shooting back” (clip 4, 12:35) is a throwaway line and also the clip’s own placement of itself on the *phantasia*-load axis, for the hunting tutorial is the low-flinch end of the spectrum. The deer does not charge, no lunging threat arrives, the flinch does not fire. The embodiment here is quiet and accumulated rather than sudden and involuntary, the patient building of a disposition by repetition rather than the acute registration of danger — and the contrast with the wolf-attack, and with the bear still to come, is precisely the axis between the low-data-discrepancy end and the high. The carcasses go to Pearson at 19:19, the kill dissolving into the camp economy and the A_4 act depositing its residue into the shared A_0 ; the *orekton* was always the camp’s, merely routed through Arthur’s hand. And then the tutor names the *hexis* outright: “Takes a lifetime of practice to master” (clip 4, 19:09) — not a skill-set but a time-built disposition, not what one can do after thirty minutes with a bow but what one becomes after a lifetime of using one. The bow-clip is the moment the tutorial says aloud what, everywhere else, it only does.

The Heist: An Acting-Together

Against the blizzard-corridor and the solitary hunt, the Cornwall train robbery is the tutorial’s collective event — the first time the full actualization of desire draws not on the player’s solitary hand but on the

gang's distributed agency, so that what is achieved cannot be credited to Arthur alone. Here Burke's consubstantiation becomes literal — "a way of life is an acting-together" (Burke, *Rhetoric*, 21), and the gang's way of life is enacted in the shared act — and here, too, the second A_0 , no longer survival but belonging, no longer the bare needful good but the earned standing, is planted before it is named. What the section establishes is that the ethical hexis has a collective register the solitary clips could not reach: the "we" that can itself source a deed.

The sequence opens at Colter, already past the blizzard horizon, with Dutch sublimating Colm O'Driscoll's personal revenge into collective provision: "much less fun to rob him if he never finds out about it" (clip 5, 06:21). The re-attribution is Burke's act-purpose ratio run deliberately, the act reframed from attitude (revenge) to purpose (plunder for the camp) so that the honor machine may score it without penalty. The approach, the cover-positioning, and the firefight through the lake camp are each a *technē*-beat, each a phase of a planned collective act in which the gang moves together and Arthur is one part of the moving whole. The Cornwall job is the fullest *technē*-lesson after the Colter corridor: Arthur kneels and unspools detonator-wire across frozen ground, the manual handling abstracted to a button-sequence while *phantasia* supplies the tension of the fuse and the cold of the metal (clip 5, 40:01). The detonator misfires — Bill's error, scored to the agent, "you're pathetic" (clip 5, 41:00) — and the consequence is immediate: board the moving train or lose the score. The leap to the train (clip 5, 42:42) is the clip's flinch-peak and its highest *phantasia*-load moment, the rush of ground beneath the car and the teetering body and the slip — "I'm slipping! Pull me up!" — all supplied by *phantasia* behind a stick and a button that perform the grab, for on a flat screen the vertigo of a moving platform is wholly image-borne, there being no vestibular organ to feel the sway. The flinch fires anyway.

At the private car (clip 5, 51:00) Dutch hands Arthur a hostage choice — "Kill them, leave them here, take them with you — just make sure they don't send no folk after us" — and the honor machine scores this fork, the playthrough taking the non-lethal path, marching the workers down the train and keeping them silent without killing. *Prohairesis* again: the deliberated act that finds the option the ethical hexis can live with. But here, unlike the bell-toll choke/spare, the honor meter responds, the act is attributed, the agent is scored — and the difference tells, for the machine sees what it is built to calibrate: not private mercy toward a begging man but publicly coherent restraint under Dutch's command. Attribution, that is, is not equal to visibility; it is equal to what the machine is designed to recognize.

"Proud of you boys. Not a man down. Outlaws for life" (clip 5, 25:29): the ethical hexis of in-group fidelity is named as a creed, not described but affirmed, the gang's shared substance offered up as an identity, the "outlaw for life" as the kind-of-thing-one-is that carries across acts. And the Kieran Duffy episode (clip 5, 27:25) deposits that creed's dark underside, the player now the agent of the lasso and the drag and the "I will break every bone in your body" addressed to a man on his knees — *bia* inflicted, agent upon patient, and no honor penalty, because the O'Driscoll is an enemy of the camp. The honor machine calibrates to in-group and out-group; the creed names the line; Kieran is the line's proof. Horseshoe Overlook arrives at 65:00 with the full A_0 re-pitch carried in four words — "This place is perfect" — and the home-base shifts and the *orekton* shifts with it, from survival to prosperity, from Dutch's grief in the blizzard to Dutch's sparkling eyes over a valley he means to hold. "The camp gets its slice" (clip 5, 65:40) is the new governing horizon, the residue of the heist depositing into a new A_0 , and the tutorial passes into its second phase.

The Camp: Dwelling Before Desire

There is a kind of being-in-a-world that has no goal — not the absence of desire but its satiation, a phase in which the *orekton* is simply to *stay* and to *be here*. The Horseshoe Overlook chore clip is this rest, a dwelling within the A_0 the heist deposited: the player grinds no quest, but chops wood, drinks coffee, and is hailed by name. What the section establishes is that a *hexis* can be deposited by sheer repetition, without any act the meter would score — that membership is laid down not in deeds but in showing up.

"Morning, Mr. Morgan" (clip 6, 00:00). The greeting is the shared-channel belonging-engine, registering not what Arthur does but that the camp *knows* him, knows him by name and acknowledges his standing at the day's first light. Burke's motive-attribution machine is here at its quietest, no scored act and no honor delta, only the agent-term pressed by a companion's bark. It is recognition of standing, not credit for a deed — and standing is exactly what the ethical hexis of belonging is, not the act but the deposit of prior acts,

the accumulated residue a gang hails when it says the agent's name at dawn. The coffee runs $A_2 \rightarrow A_4$ in three seconds: the pot at the fire becomes a *phantasma* of warmth, the *doxa* forms — *this is my morning* — the button is pressed, the animation runs. And the warmth of the cup, the bitterness, the radiated heat are supplied wholly by *phantasia* across the screen's data-discrepancy, the felt body at rest and at home furnished by image-making from the backlog of every morning the player has ever spent before a fire. The woodpile runs the same arc at a slower register, the axe swinging and the log splitting and the contribution ticking, and the game barely scores it — no honor pulse, no dramatic residue, only work done for the camp, labor as membership rather than as scored act.

It is here that Calleja's apparatus earns its place most plainly, for the channel-profile of camp-dwelling is unlike any combat beat the tutorial has run. The spatial, kinesthetic, and affective channels are dominant — the player moving through a bounded place, doing the things the place asks, and being seen to do them (Calleja, *In-Game*, 36–38) — while the ludic channel, the engagement with consequential choice, falls to near-zero, no goal pressing and nothing won or lost. "Good work, Mr. Morgan," should the greeting fire mid-chore, is the agent-term once more, character recognized not from a single act but from the pattern of showing up. Across the long ambient loops no new *orekton* opens. The clip cultivates not a desire but a disposition, the readiness to be present and to do the labor that dwelling requires and to receive the greeting that proves one belongs — the *hexis* of membership, depositing quietly and by repetition alone, since one chore deposits nothing and a hundred chores deposit everything. The blizzard-survival horizon has closed; the standing-and-belonging horizon is now the ground.

Heidegger's second form of boredom bears directly on this stretch, and on that dominant channel-profile — not the boredom of waiting for something but the being-bored-*with* a situation one nonetheless remains in, the being-held in an empty time that yet discloses the world as a whole (Heidegger, *Fundamental Concepts*, 120–124). The looping "Morning, Mr. Morgan," the chore-prompt, the woodpile, the fire: this is exactly that texture, the camp as a world one is bored-with and yet does not leave, because remaining is itself the disposition the tutorial is building. The second-form boredom is not the analysis's target but the phenomenal register in which the *hexis* of dwelling sediments — the ludic channel near silent, the spatial and affective channels carrying the whole.

The Town: Honor as Motive-Attribution Machine

If the camp is where the ethical *hexis* is cultivated quietly, the Valentine trip is where the calibration of the honor machine is put on open display, and where its design-assumptions are brought to the surface. Within thirty minutes the player is handed five consecutive honor-positive events, and in the spaces between them Arthur twice disclaims the very virtue the machine has just credited him — and these two movements, the scoring and the disclaiming, are what the section is built to set against each other.

The first event opens the sequence: a stranger, feigning lumbago, needs his horse retrieved, and Arthur retrieves it and returns it, the meter bumping. "You're a gentleman, sir." And Arthur: "No, not really. I was just trying to impress the women" (clip 7, 07:45). This is the Burkean scene-agent ratio made explicit by the agent himself, the honorable act credited by the machine to his character and re-credited by the character to an audience — the women the scene-condition without which he would have robbed the man. The machine scores what it sees; Arthur reports what moved him; and neither attribution is false, nor is either complete. Then, a beat later: "If you lot hadn't been here, I probably would have robbed them" (clip 7, 08:40). Uncle supplies the scene-attribution in the very form the honor machine elides, for the machine cannot read the subjunctive — the robbery that did not happen because the witnesses were watching — and so scores only the act that did, and scores it to the agent. The dispositions on display are not identical to the scores that track them: this is the clip's first payload, that honor-attribution and moral truth diverge, and that the character names the divergence for the player while the machine files its report.

Tilly's grab (clip 7, 23:00), Karen's beating (clip 7, 24:16), and Jimmy's dangling plea (clip 7, 28:38) are three *bia* events, three de-inversions, three honor-gains, the structure rhythmic — patient to rescuer, each act coded to the agent's standing. But the acts themselves are mixed: intervening for Tilly is protective and uncalculated, a scene-reflex. Beating the john in the hotel room is violent in excess of the need, Arthur striking him "a lot harder" than he hit Karen, as Karen reports afterward (clip 7, 26:50). The honor machine scores both alike, because it cannot read degree. The motive-attribution pentad has a slot for act and a slot

for agent, and what falls into each is fixed by the geometry of the scene and not by the player's conscience.

Jimmy Brooks is the clip's keystone. The player has chased him down, lassoed him from horseback, and hauled him to a ledge — all *bia* inflicted, the player the agent of force against a begging man — and then at 30:00 Arthur hauls him up rather than dropping him, and the meter rewards it. The speech that follows is the tutorial's most complete pentad in a single breath: "I'm not a good man, Jimmy Brooks... I was in Blackwater. I kill people. And maybe I should have killed you... I never saw you. We have an understanding" (clip 7, 30:00) — scene (Blackwater, the fugitive life), agent (Arthur naming himself a killer), act (spare and intimidate), purpose (the gang's safety), attitude (mercy edged with menace). The honor machine scores the spare as positive, and the player's conscience must supply the weight of the coercion that surrounds it. One terminal is moral credit, the other an asymmetric power relation enforced by the threat of death, and the machine scores the one and is silent on the other. At 32:10 Arthur returns the commandeered horse — "You really were just borrowing it. Appreciate it" — and the loop closes. The ethical *hexis* of these thirty minutes is not clean virtue but its approximation under particular scene-conditions, witnesses and women and a fugitive who can name the gang. Strip those conditions away, and Arthur is his own narrator's confession, "I probably would have robbed them." What the machine deposits is a score. What the chapter cultivates is what the score can only approximate — the disposition to act honorably when the scene calls for it, tracked by a machine that cannot read the gap between the disposition and its measure.

The Legendary Hunt: The *Technē* at Ceiling

Where the hunting tutorial was legible because Charles narrated every stage — "get your eye in," "good tension on the string," "let's try for another" — the legendary hunt is diagnostic precisely because it is silent. Its transcript is nothing but the Whisper model's "you," repeated every thirty seconds for twenty-five minutes. No tutor speaks, no stage is named, and the *hexis* seeded under Charles's narration is now enacted without it — the absence of narration being the very mark that the disposition has settled. What the section establishes is what a mature *hexis* looks like from the outside: not instruction, only enacted competence.

The player whistles for the horse and the horse comes. Eagle Eye is toggled and the quarry resolves from the residue. Dead Eye is drawn and time slows and the painted marks land — and none of it is taught here, for all of it was taught in the corridor and the bow-clip and the heist and has since sedimented, the act now running untutored. The horse-bond contributes what the hunting tutorial did not, a care toward an animal that sits between *technē* and ethics: the grooming and feeding of the mount (clip 9, 05:00–07:30) build no toward-the-hunt capability, yet the bond they cultivate is what lets the horse respond at ceiling — the smooth gait, the obeyed rein, the re-attuned spook. The bond is the ethical hinge the honor machine never scores, because the care-act is private and unnested and received only by an animal. Yet it modulates the *technē* throughout, the hunter's ground-cover and the mounted traversal both running differently on a bonded horse, the unscored act depositing into the scored performance.

The bear charges (clip 9, 11:00): the image lunges at the screen, and the player's body pulls back. This is the pure specimen the analysis has been building toward — the involuntary recoil, embodiment as flinch, the felt body on a flat screen supplied by *phantasia* with no headset in the circuit. The bear does not move toward the player, for there is no spatial "toward"; the flat image advances within its frame, and still the player ducks. Here is the 2D pole's deepest claim: that *phantasia* scales to the gap, supplying what the medium withholds, and that at the moment of a charging animal it supplies *enough* to move the body — not as much as a headset predator would, which would place the charge in space and deliver it vestibularly, but enough to fire the recoil through a screen. Against the bear, the legendary hunt itself (clip 9, 16:30–22:30) stacks three *phantasia*-prostheses the pole cannot do without. The first is Eagle Eye, the tracking-vision filter that supplies in perception-highlight what the trained body would hold as a gaze. The second is the legendary aura, the world-tint that marks the quarry's range as special, supplying in UI-desaturation what the experienced hunter might hold as a felt strangeness. The third is Dead Eye, the time-slow, composure rendered as mechanic, supplying in slowed frames what the practiced shooter holds as steadied attention. Three eidetic and affective states that a body in a headset might begin to hold proprioceptively are here, on the flat screen, converted each to a filter, a tint, or a slowdown — the 2D pole's instruments of compensation made visible all at once in a single encounter. The legendary pelt goes onto the horse, the trophy-*orekton* taken and the mastery-*orekton* consummated, and the clip ends in silence: no one names what happened,

no "Good work, Arthur," no "takes a lifetime of practice to master." The *technē*-hexis at ceiling is its own testimony.

The Drunk Night: Loosened Agency

Against the hunt's concentrated mastery, the drunk night with Lenny puts a different claim on the table — that *bia* need not be violent to be analytically productive, and that the 2D pole's highest *phantasia*-load is not the predator's charge but the corrupted screen. A caveat is owed at the outset: this clip's transcript was wholly irrecoverable, rated in its beatmap as "100% whisper hallucination" with no coherent English dialogue, and so its mechanics — the drunk-cam and the brawl-arc described below — are analytically inferred from the clip's role and framing, pending frame-verification, rather than grounded in a transcript as its siblings are.

The herbalist challenge opens the clip — Eagle Eye scanning the field for herbs, the hold-to-pick animation returning the foraging competence the hunting clips installed — a *technē*-hexis of collection, thin and quiet, $A_0 \rightarrow A_4$ in a slow loop, the herb a *phantasma* charged with the completionist *orekton*, the *doxa* "this counts," the pick, the counter's tick. The game paints the ground with highlights, the player reads the painting, and the camp-provision grows by increment, nothing rupturing and nothing flinching. Then come the saloon, and Lenny, and the drinks. Intoxication in *Red Dead Redemption 2* is rendered not through the avatar but through the display: the screen blurs, sways, doubles, and trails — a drunk-cam applied not to the character's eyes but to the player's own viewport — so that the sober player must process a drunk image. This is the pole's most explicit gambit, for the felt body of drunkenness, the heaviness and the narrowed field and the unreliable coordination, cannot be delivered through a flat display by any other means. The game delivers instead the *appearance* of intoxication to the player's perception and relies on *phantasia* to supply the rest, high data-discrepancy translated now not into perceptual thinness but into perceptual distortion — the gap no longer between screen and world but between the sober eye and the drunk image it is made to read.

What loosens is agency. The controls fight back, the camera drifts, aim and movement degrade to stumbling — *bia* in its softest and most consensual register, not the O'Driscoll ambush stripping control without warning but a gradual, player-initiated, willingly undertaken cession of mastery. The *orekton* is oblivion and companionship. The player drinks because drinking is the act the world is soliciting, because Lenny is there and the night is warm and the camp has just proven itself. And the *hexis* cultivated here is neither combat-readiness nor the hunter's competence but the male solidarity of shared misrule — camaraderie as *hexis*, belonging as letting-go. Burke's pentad raises a question the scene leaves open: when the drunken antics accrue — the stumbling, the brawling, the saloon commotion incited — to which term does the honor machine attribute them, to the agent (Arthur's character) or to the agency (the drink, the scene)? The transcript can give no answer, and the attribution can be settled only from frames. But the question is itself the point, for the machine's calibration, which the Valentine clip displayed in its positive direction, is here exposed on its negative side — a machine that cannot read the scene-condition of intoxication must either score the agent or ignore the act, and whichever it does tells us whose motive it was built to track. The morning returns Arthur to sobriety and the camp to its routines, the Lenny bond deepened and another A_4 deposited into the ethical-hexis bundle. But the pole has shown what neither camp nor town could — that *phantasia* may be conscripted by corrupting the image as readily as by withholding the data, that the high-load end of the spectrum holds the drunk-cam no less than the bear-charge, and that the felt body of altered consciousness is, on a flat screen, entirely the player's own supply.

The Disposition Built

Three hours of tutorial; three re-pitchings of the governing desire; one dual hexis-bundle deposited across combat and camp-chores and heist and solitary hunt and a drunk saloon night with a friend. What the tutorial has built is neither a skill-set nor a personality but a *paideia* (παιδεία) — a standing readiness to act in certain ways in certain kinds of situation, cultivated by repetition until it runs without instruction. The *technē*-hexis runs untutored in the legendary hunt because it was tutored in the corridor and the bow-clip

and the heist and has sedimented. The ethical hexis runs across the camp and the town and the drunk night without any explicit lesson in virtue because Dutch's grief-speech seeded the orienting good and each subsequent resolution has deepened its furrow. Neither hexis was set by a curriculum; the tutorial designed a world, and the world cultivated the disposition.

This is what the RODA analysis discloses when it is run across the whole tutorial arc: not a series of discrete events but a protracted hexis-bundle, a single compound disposition deposited incrementally, each clip adding a layer the next draws upon, the whole intelligible only from its end looking back. The opening cutscene names an Arthur before the player can act; the legendary hunt shows what that Arthur has become once the player has acted for three hours. Between those poles lies the tutorial, a *paideia* on rails, building the disposition that will run the rest of the game. The two strands are by now one bundle — the *technē*-hexis that draws a bow in silence and the ethical hexis that spares a begging man under the eyes of witnesses — and the bundle is the prepared agent the open world will inherit.

It was built, moreover, by the route the flat screen makes necessary, and that route is the chapter's contribution to the differential the two cases compose. Where the head-mounted world of *Gnomes & Goblins* hands the body its surround and asks little of the image, the screen withholds the surround and asks everything — the cold of the blizzard, the heft of the drawn bow, the lurch of the leaping train, the recoil from the charging bear, each supplied by the player's own *phantasia* across a data-discrepancy the medium never closes. And where the eye alone will not suffice, the design lends prostheses — Eagle Eye for the tracker's gaze, Dead Eye for the marksman's composure, the drunk-cam for the swimming head — the 2D pole's standing instruments of compensation. The disposition deposited is the same kind of thing the virtual-reality world deposited at the other pole, an incorporation that sediments into a *hexis*. What differs is only the road to it, and that road, in the screen-based case, runs through the image and not the body. The VR pole reaches its dwelling by giving the body its world; the 2D pole reaches the same dwelling by making the player imagine one.

The rails will come off. The world will open, the camp economy will expand, Valentine will become a hub, and the seeds planted in the heist and the town will begin to bear. Everything the tutorial deposited will be drawn upon across the forty hours that follow — and tested, when the gang the loyalty-hexis was built around begins to come apart, against Micah's corrosive creed and Dutch's slow erosion and the moment in the game's last act when the disposition is all that remains. But those tests belong to the disruption, and the disruption is the subject of the section the footage will let me write. What the tutorial built was the world that is made to break.

(The §2 disruption analysis of Red Dead Redemption 2 — the counterpart to the Gnomes & Goblins disruption above — is pending capture of the Sonny-scene footage; four beats noted here await frame-verification before the final pass: the choke/spare bell-toll timing, the hostage-fork honor delta, the bear-maul confirmation, and the drunk-brawl honor attribution.)